# The Rivergator

*A Paddler's Guide to the*
*Lower Mississippi River Water Trail*

By John Ruskey

Lower Mississippi River Foundation

SAMPLE CHAPTER: Memphis to Helena
Mile 737 to Mile 663

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*Complete guide covers 1,100 miles: St. Louis to the Gulf of Mexico*


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# Memphis to Helena

*Mile 737-663*

# Introduction

# Introduction

*Memphis to Helena — Mile 737-663*

Rivergator: Memphis to Helena MM 736 - 663 © 2013 John Ruskey For the Rivergator : Lower Mississippi River Water Trail The www.rivergator.org is a free public use website presented by the Lower Mississippi River Foundation. Re-printing of text and photos by permission only with proper credits. Intro: Memphis to Helena: Welcome to the 2013 update to the Rivergator : Paddlers Guide to the Lower Mississippi River! This section covers the 73 miles of the big river from the pyramid city of Memphis to the paddler's oasis Helena Arkansas. After leaving downtown Memphis you'll swish under the last three bridges and some industry along the south bluff, and then you'll quickly return to the wilds of the Lower Mississippi with nothing but forested islands, big river and big open skies as your scenery. Of course there'll be towboats and fishermen and a few casinos along the way, but it's amazing how quickly the city disappears into the wilderness. You'll camp on beaches the size and feel of Caribbean beaches, and paddle through narrow chutes with lush overhanging willows and cottonwoods. You?ll be hemmed in by revetment and dikes in one place, and then released into long sections of the main channel where the floodplain forest and riverbank wetlands are still connected directly to the river, creating an incredibly vibrant ecosystem of bayous, sluices, chutes, pools, and back channels overflowing with wildlife, notably at Tunica Runout and the mouth of the St. Francis River. Geography: After exiting the Missouri Boot-Heel and bouncing along the Chickasaw Bluffs past Memphis, the Mighty Mississippi flows southwesterly in giant meandering loops into the verdant and fantastically fertile Mississippi Delta. This is the land that gave birth to the Delta Blues, and was once the cotton kingdom of the world. Its forest was America's Amazon, millions of acres of deep woods now removed for farmland. Leaving Tennessee and entering Mississippi the paddler is welcomed by a long line of casinos that rivals Atlantic City, but which you'll see little evidence of as you paddle behind long chains of islands in the same area, although you should stop for a visit to the Tunica Riverpark Museum. The river carves elegant S-curves through deep woods as it meanders through Commerce Bend, Mhoon Bend and Walnut Bend, and then wanders down through a floodplain fifteen miles wide to the mouth of the St. Francis River. The St. Francis is the biggest west bank tributary downstream of St. Louis. The big river engulfs mind-boggling swaths of muddy landscapes as it is forced southerly by the

strange geophysical anomaly Crowley’s Ridge, which parallels the Mississippi out of Missouri. Buck Island invites exploration, picnicking or camping, and Helena, Arkansas commands the base of Crowley’s Ridge. As result of the high ground Helena is the only population in between Memphis and Vicksburg (300 miles) that sits right on the main channel. Visit the Delta Cultural Center, or coordinate your adventure with one of the world’s greatest celebrations of music, the King Biscuit Blues Festival (October). Canoeists, SUPs and kayakers will find provisions, maps, gear, and paddling tips at Quapaw Canoe Company in Helena, as well as water and Wi-Fi.

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NOTE TO PADDLERS: The Rivergator is for your free use! Please print or access from your smart phone. (Presented here in roughly 100 miles sections from St. Louis to the Gulf of Mexico). Best case scenario: 1) print up section of Rivergator that you will be canoeing or kayaking. 2) Print up accompanying USACE river maps. 3) Print up NOAA River Stage Forecasts the day before you embark on your adventure for latest readings and forecast. 4) Lastly, listen to and print up latest weather forecast. Secure the above by inserting pages into 8.5x11 page protectors and bundle into a 3-ring notebook or waterproof map casing (available at most water outfitters such as Outdoors Inc. Memphis or online at REI or NRS). If using a smart phone be sure and protect with water-proof casing! The river is hungry for electronic devices and equipment that doesn’t float! (I have personally left several marine radios, a half dozen knives and one camera with the sturgeon and catfish at the bottom of the river!) The Rivergator is a public service brought to you compliments of the Lower Mississippi River Foundation with support from dozens of river experts and partner organizations Who is the Rivergator written For? The Rivergator is written by paddlers for paddlers. It will open the river for local experienced canoeists who have always wanted to paddle the Mississippi but didn’t know how or when or where to start and is appropriate for canoe clubs, kayak clubs and outdoor clubs, outdoor leadership schools, friends & families, and church groups & youth groups. It could be used by the Girl Scouts for a week-long summer expedition to Tunica, or a group of Boy Scouts working on their canoe badge in the Memphis area -- or a group of KIPP middle schoolers from Helena who want to get on the river at the mouth of the St. Francis for an easy daytrip. Paddlers seek out new places to explore. You could read the Rivergator during the winter months from your home and by spring snowmelt you could be making your first paddle

strokes on a life-changing adventure down the Mississippi! Rivergator will help you get there if you're a long-distance canoeist who started at Lake Itasca, or a kayaker who is coming through south after paddling the length of the Missouri River from Montana's Bitterroot Mountains. You could be a stand-up-paddleboarder who put in at the Great River Confluence of the Upper Mississippi and Big Muddy Missouri in St. Louis. Regardless of where you wo;; be starting the Rivergator can help you in your journey.

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We paddlers are all the same: we are canoeists, kayakers, stand-up-paddleboarders, rafters. We look for the same kinds of currents on the river, and enjoy the same kinds of remote islands. We are slow, but efficient. We know the river better than any other river pilots, at least the pieces of river we have paddled on. Yet we have more in common with towboats than motorboats. Regardless of what you paddle, the Rivergator will you help you find the essential landings and the obscure back channels that you would otherwise miss. It will help you safely paddle around towboats, and choose the best line of travel to follow around the head-turning bends and intimidating dikes, wing dams, and other rock structures. It will identify which islands to camp and which to avoid, and where the best picnic spots are found and where blue holes form. It will lead you to places of prolific wildlife and mind-blowing beauty. It will help explain some of the mysterious motions of the biggest river in North America. It's written for canoeists and kayakers, but is readable enough to be enjoyed by any arm-chair adventurers including landowners, hunters, fishermen, communities along the route, historians, biologists, geologists, and other river-lovers. The river is the key to understanding the history, the geography and the culture of the Mid-South. It's the first high speed "router." It connected our ancestors much like the internet does today. It's the original American highway, migration route, freight route, newspaper route, and trade route. But it's also a church, a sanctuary, a playground, a classroom. The river is the rock star, and as such the Rivergator is a guide to help you interpret and enjoy the songs of the river! Reading the Rivergator : The Rivergator reads like a big river expedition, starting above St. Louis at the confluence of the Missouri and following the Middle and then Lower Mississippi downstream mile-by-mile. (Note: we are currently in the second year of a four year project: ultimate start place will be St. Louis, with end place in the Gulf of Mexico, almost 1200 miles of free-flowing river) The descriptions are factual and the information is the most up-to-date available, but I have tried to enliven the

writing with “the feel” whenever possible. Each piece is titled with headings in bold that include 1) the name of the important features along the way, 2) which side of the river it’s on, and 3) its mileage. For example, “LBD Mile 736 Memphis, Tennessee, Mud Island Harbor.” 736 is the mileage above the head of passes near the Gulf of Mexico. RBD=right bank descending and LBD=left bank descending. Paddlers are offered many route choices beyond the main channel in the plethora of sluices, back channels, secret passages, and tributaries along the way, using Google maps for illustration. On your laptop or home computer you could open two pages, one for the text and one for Google maps. On the river you can switch back and forth on your smart phone. Or you can print the text and use the US Army Corps’ Lower Mississippi Maps hard copy or online. The Rivergator is three guides wrapped up into one, because every island, landing and riverbank has to be described in three different water levels, low, medium and high. It provides paddling routes, as well as history, geography and culture. The Mississippi fluctuates 40-50 vertical feet in any given year, with enormous changes as result, whole islands disappear in high water, while some good landings become fields of mud at low water.

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Panel of Experts: All writing is reviewed by a panel of paddlers, naturalists and other river experts including (for this section) Bruce Van Wyngarden, big river pilot and founding editor of The Memphis Flyer ; Joe Royer, pioneering Memphis kayaker and founder of Outdoors Inc.; Dale Sanders, big river kayaker and adventurer extraordinaire; Beth Wiedower, Arkansas Rural Delta Heritage Initiative, Terry Eastin, Director of the Mississippi River Trail; Colton Cockrum, river canoeist and founder of the Memphis River Warriors; Bayard Morgan, canoeist and river advocate; Bubba Battle, canoe builder and paddler; Rick Howe, structural engineer, river rat; Julia Malinowski, Helena Tourism Director; Kevin Smith, historian and big river paddler; Bill Branch, curator Delta Cultural Center; Peggy Linton, Community Foundation of Northwest Mississippi; Larry Jerrett Canoeist, river advocate; Kevin Pierson, National Audubon Society Lower Mississippi Program; Ernest Herndon, canoeist, author of Canoeing Mississipp i and also Canoeing Louisiana, Paul Hartfield, biologist, pilot, big river expert; Mark River Peoples, big river guide, Chris “Wolfie” Staudinger, big river guide, and Braxton Barden, big river guide and mariner. I, John Ruskey, am primary author. I have been taking notes, photographs and documenting the river since my first raft trip down the Mississippi in 1982, and so the Rivergator is the culmination

of 30 years of exploration. I have paddled the Mississippi on anything that floats including a log. To verify all information I have been making “refresher expeditions,” (I last paddled this section with a team of explorers during the June rise, 2013). I’ll try to keep myself out of it as much as possible, and let the river speak for herself. But I’ll also spice the journey with stories and vignettes from my adventures along the way, and others who have first-hand experience. Other important Rivergator sources include the National Weather Service “Lower Mississippi River Gauge and Week Forecast,” the US Army Corps 2007 Flood Control and Navigation Maps: Mississippi River, Google Maps Satellite View, Marion Braggs’ Historic Names and Places on the Lower Mississippi River , Mark Twain’s Life on the Mississippi , Historic-Memphis.com, The Tennessee Valley Authority, The City of Memphis, The Lower Mississippi River Conservation Committee, Herman Melville’s The Confidence Man , Wikipedia, Quapaw Canoe Company and Wild Miles. See “Sources” for complete listing and suggestions for further reading. Wild Miles: The wonderful thing about the Lower Miss is that it’s still wild! You will see some industry and agriculture between Memphis and Helena, but for the most part your experience will be big water, big forests, big sandbars, big bluffs and big skies! Does this sound like Alaska? Or Lake Superior? Or Puget Sound? Yes -- but it’s not. It’s nothing but the muddy big river, the biggest river in North America, and the longest stretch of free-flowing waters in the Lower 48. In this section the wild places include Mile 725 to 664, 61 Wild Miles from below Memphis Harbor to above Helena Note: Tunica RiverPark & Museum, Buck Island protected public-use island. Some casinos can be seen with their right night lights. The lights of Memphis are dimly seen along northern horizon. Casino section Mile 708-695 might need to be removed from Wild Miles.

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What are the Wild Miles? According to www.wildmiles.org there are 515 Wild Miles on the Lower Mississippi River between Cairo, Illinois, and Baton Rouge, Louisiana, which means that 71% of the scenery viewed from canoes or kayaks paddling down that stretch of river looks & feels “wild.” Wild Miles are the places along the river where nature predominates and nothing is seen of mankind save passing tows (and other river traffic) and maybe a tiny hunting camp or a single fisherman buzzing by in a johnboat. These are places where the landscape is filled with giant islands bounded by endless mud banks and sandbars, where the river is overseen by big skies and where the sun sets uninterrupted by buildings or wires and where big river predominates with

creative wild beauty, each high water results in shifting sand dunes and re-made sandbars. This is a floodplain valley where only deer and coyote tracks are seen along the sandbars and enormous flocks of shy birds like the White Pelican and Double Breasted Cormorant are comfortable enough to make landing for the night. These are places where it's dark & quiet at night, where the stars fill the skies like brightly shining jewels poured out on a dark purple velvet blanket, almost as thick and vibrant as the night skies of the Great Plains or Rocky Mountains. America has an opportunity to find the wilderness within by recognizing and preserving the below Wild Miles in the center of the country, and it just so happens that the gigantic floodplain of the Mississippi creates these Wild Miles. These places have been preserved mostly by neglect, by the power of the river, by its catastrophic rises and falls, and the danger of building anything within its floodplain. Moreover, in light of recent flood cycles and the declining population of the lower floodplain, this area is receiving attention as one of the best places to restore native bottomland hardwood forests. Restored forest creates habitat for wildlife, improved water quality, a buffer to flooding, and is an important means of reducing the Gulf of Mexico's dead zone, caused by nutrient runoff into the river. For this reason the recent efforts to reopen the New Madrid Birdspoint floodway would have a detrimental effect on the entire Lower Miss, at the very least in flood control. Developers: Instead of building any new sites within these Wild Miles, please consider placing new industry and agriculture construction outside the Wild Miles -- and stay within those places already industrialized such as within one of the many harbors along the way, or building it far enough behind the levee that it won't be seen or heard or be directly connected to the river. Big Trees and Floodplain: The lower Mississippi River Valley was historically a vast expanse of bottomland and adjacent upland hardwood forests with scattered openings primarily created by fire, beaver, or large flood events by the Mississippi River and its tributaries. These openings were generally comprised of herbaceous moist-soil areas that harbored excellent waterfowl and other wetland wildlife habitat or giant switchcane that was almost impenetrable and an extremely important habitat component for a variety of wildlife species. Once covering 22 million acres in the Mississippi River Alluvial Plain, bottomland hardwood forests have decreased in extent to only 4.9 million acres. Extensive clearing for agriculture (i.e. soybeans, corn, or cotton) and urbanization are two of the primary reasons giant bald cypress and oak trees of pre-settlement times no longer exist. However, giant bald cypress and oak trees characteristic of

yesteryear can still be seen on some of these sections of the Lower Mississippi.

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Important Note to Paddlers: The Lower Mississippi is not for beginners, although there a couple of side channel places that beginners can get a taste of the big waters (such as Mud Island Memphis Harbor, Tunica Lake, the mouth of the St. Francis and the Helena Harbor -- and other protected flat water places connected to the big river -- see page “Beginner Paddlers on the Lower Mississippi River”). Advance paddlers only in the main channel. You should be capable of self-rescue, and you should have previous big river experience, in specific: large volume waters with long crossings and industrial traffic (towboats). Your skills should include self-rescue, long ferry-crossings, paddling in the wind, paddling in the vicinity of towboats, paddling through violent boils, violent eddies, and large whirlpools. Ultimately you must decide whether you are capable of safely paddling the big river, and whether you are capable of leading your family or friends on the same. Be cautious. Take your time. Swallow your ambition and pride. Impatience has been the root cause of most problems encountered by Lower Mississippi River paddlers. Enjoy the moment, not the destination. Turn around if you aren’t sure or aren’t prepared. Use the Rivergator Safety section to assess specific skills and recommendations. Check the river levels and weather forecast with special attention to wind speed and direction. Carry extra food, water, and all-weather protection. Wear wetsuit or drysuit in cold water seasons (generally November through April, but could begin in October and could extend into May). Carry cell phone and VHF Marine radio. Carry an extra paddle and leave a route plan with someone on shore. Large groups can notify the Coast Guard who will keep the towboat pilots informed of your progress. Your route: Main Channel vs. Back Channel The Rivergator will detail Main Channel which is almost always the fastest route on the water, but full or traffic, and Back Channel , which is slower but is full of wildlife and big trees. Main channel is always open regardless of river level, but back channel is dependent upon river levels. Most back channels are closed in low water, open with slow flow in medium water, and full of strong flowing currents in high water. Main channel hazards are buoys and towboats. (Avoid both!). Dikes found on the edges of the main channel can cause violent turbulence, strong boils, eddies, and radical changes of current, and oftentimes whirlpools. Be especially cautious around the ends of any dikes. In the back channel your main hazards are waterfalls over dikes (dependent on river level), snags, strainers and

channel blockages (driftwood piling against trees or low bridges). Rivergator will detail all known waterfalls and blockages. But on the river things are in constant flux. What one year is an uninterrupted flowing back channel might next year be blocked by a pile of logs and tree removal dropped by some logging operation. Two things: 1) be a smart paddler and use you own best judgment about what's safe to paddle and what isn't. And 2) let us know if you discover something of importance not listed in the Rivergator , like a dangerous waterfall or a blocked channel. That way we can update Rivergator descriptions and keep other paddlers informed about these difficulties and possible hazards! Dikes present special challenges to the back channel paddler. At low water they are exposed, and you can paddle around any dike, but you will often discover strong eddies with ripping cross currents and whirlpools. At medium water you can paddle over most dikes, but that is when the waters are at their most turbulent. You may not see any solid evidence, but you will know they are there by the exploding boils, whipping currents, whirlpools and agitated turbulence. In high water most dikes get swamped over by smooth flow and you hardly notice their influence. In medium water back channels waterfalls sometimes form over a dike, with significant drops (2-3 feet), strong v-line tongues, standing waves, and turbulent side waters. If you hear the sound of rushing water and see the plane of the back channel disappear and drop a level, and see leaping whitewater beyond -- Be especially cautious! Remember the paddler's mantra: when in doubt, stop and scout!

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Intro: Memphis: Water Levels For this portion of Rivergator Trail we refer to the Memphis Gauge which we'll denote as "MG." Further downstream (at Mhoon Landing) we'll switch over to the Helena Gauge which we'll denote as "HG." For daily river levels and weekly forecasts, go to http://www.srh.noaa.gov/lmrfc/?n=lmrfc-mississippiandohioriverforecast Water levels according to the Memphis Gauge Low Water = -5 to 15 MG Medium Water = 15 to 25 MG High Water = 25 to 34 MG Flood Stage = 34 MG and above MG = Memphis Gauge Flood Stage Warning: above 34 MG paddlers are advised to stay off the river. Limited access. Most landings and approach roads will be underwater. Most islands will be gone. No easy camping. All sandbars will be covered. Fast waters with many hazards. All islands and landings will be surrounded by flooded forests full of snags, strainers, sawyers and all other dangerous conditions associated with floodwater moving through trees. Docks,

wharves, dikes and any other man-made objects will create strong whirlpools, violent boils, and fast eddies. Towboats will create large waves. The Rivergator will not describe the river and its islands at any levels above flood stage. Lower Mississippi and Ohio River Forecast The Lower Mississippi and Ohio River Forecast is a fascinating document and will reveal many qualities of the river to the careful reader and interpreter of this gauge. You can also jump from this page following its links to many associated NOAA pages full of useful information about the various Lower Mississippi River Gauges, as well as historical records, flood records, low water occurrences, observed precipitation throughout the valley, snowpack, ground saturation, rain forecasts, and other meteorologic and hydrologic aspects leading to current river conditions and accurate predictions. You can also follow links to the same for readings and predictions from the Ohio River Valley, the Middle Miss, Upper Miss and Missouri River Valleys, which all of course confluence and combine to form the big waters of the Lower Mississippi River. The River forecasts typically include “water on the ground and forecast for next 24 hrs,” which is good to be aware when planning multi-day river trips. Water Levels and Dikes In the Memphis area you can use the following scale to gauge water flowing over dikes, although some dikes vary in height. Also some have been “notched” in recent years as result there will be a middle notch that you can paddle through at much lower levels of water, some places down to 0 Memphis Gauge. Using the Memphis Gauge: 1-9 MG water flowing through notches only 10 MG - rocks still exposed on all dikes 11-12 MG dikes starting to go under, some flow through breaks & low spots 13 MG dikes completely under, but little flow 15-20 MG good flow and lots of boils & turbulence 20 MG strong flow, turbulence, no dikes exposed anywhere 30 MG river bank full >34 MG Flood Stage. Warning: above 34 MG paddlers are advised to stay off the river. Limited access. Most landings and approach roads will be underwater. Most islands will be gone. No easy camping. All sandbars will be covered. Fast waters with many hazards. All islands and landings will be surrounded by flooded forests full of snags, strainers, sawyers and all other dangerous conditions associated with floodwater moving through trees. Docks, wharves, dikes and any other man-made objects will create strong whirlpools, violent boils, and fast eddies. Towboats will create large waves. The Rivergator will not describe the river and its islands at any levels above flood stage.

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Reading Google Maps You can learn a lot about the

Mississippi River using Google satellite maps, bearing in mind certain parameters. Firstly the Google map-images were recorded from space during a season of low water, hence the islands and sandbars are at their largest, and many back channels that are open at higher water levels appear to be closed. Unlike highways which don't change shape or position with the seasons, the islands of the Mississippi River and their back channels are dramatically affected by water levels. And so the paddler needs to remember that the shapes of low-lying landmarks like the sandbars and wetlands seen on Google Satellite Maps or Google Earth is probably not what they are like on any given day when you are out on the river. Be forewarned not to assume that the perfect-looking sandbar you see on your iPhone will be there! Secondly, river levels change with the Google Maps zoom. Take Choctaw Island for example. When you go to Satellite view for the Mississippi River near Arkansas City you will see that Google employs various depictions of Choctaw Island. (I have created map at: http://g.co/maps/wmese ) Use the zoom tool to change scale. Pay attention to scale icon at bottom left. At zoom 1 = 1 mile and above you can see the back channel partially open & flowing well. The water level is probably around 3AG. However change the zoom to 2 = 1mile and lower you will see the back channel almost completely occluded by sandbars. The water level in this depiction is certainly -4AG or lower. Thirdly, for amorphous locations like river confluences and shifty river islands, what's seen on Google Terrain may not be what's seen on Google Satellite. The maps from the mouth of the Arkansas are a good case in point. Click on the map I created for the Mouth of the Arkansas Round Trip http://g.co/maps/syhs8 Look at it in Terrain, and then go to Satellite. You will see that the Arkansas River channel occupies different channels! This is not a mistake on Google's part. What you see in Terrain is from the 1972 USGS survey. Since then the Arkansas has chosen a new path and carved out a new confluence location two miles from the older one. This is the nature of this ephemeral river-scape. It will be interesting to see how the current Arkansas River channel changes in the upcoming years, and how well Google will keep up with it. Lower Mississippi River Mileage Mileage indicates miles above the Head of Passes, the ground zero of the Mississippi River, the fork in the road 10 miles below Venice and 90 miles below New Orleans where the Mississippi splits into its Delta channels as it pours into the Gulf of Mexico the three primary channel being the Southwest Pass, the South Pass and the Pass L'Outre. All mileage between Cairo and the Caribbean is measured on this scale, New Orleans at 95, Baton Rouge 230, St. Francisville 265, Natchez 363,

Vicksburg 437, Greenville 537, Helena 663, Memphis 737, Caruthersville 846, New Madrid 889, and Ohio River 954. The mouth of the Ohio River at Cairo Illinois is mile 0 for the Middle Mississippi (180 miles upstream to the Missouri River Confluence) and mile 982 for the Ohio River (up to Pittsburgh).

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Rivergator The title Rivergator is derived from the runaway best-seller The Navigator first published in 1801 by Zadok Kramer, with 25 or 30 subsequent printings. The Navigator described the Mississippi Valley for pioneer settlers streaming out of the Eastern United States in the first great wave of continental migrations that led to the settling of the West. Thomas Jefferson and other leaders were fearful that the French or the English would get there first. With the Lewis & Clark explorations and the introduction of the steamboat to the Mississippi River in 1812, Americans followed the big rivers up and down through the heart of the country, and The Navigator was their guide. In this spirit I have adopted the name Rivergator with the hope that America's forgotten outdoor paradise the Lower Mississippi, the wilderness within, will be used by successive generations of canoeists and kayakers. Zadoc Cramer also invented the numbering system for Lower Mississippi River Islands. Mileage All points, islands landings, and features will be identified with the mileage system used on the 2007 US Army Corps of Engineer River Maps, which can be viewed or downloaded as a pdf from: http://www2.mvn.usace.army.mil/eng/miss_river_books.asp
Left Bank and Right Bank RBD = Right Bank Descending LBD = Left Bank Descending The Rivergator will use the standard left bank descending (LBD) and right bank descending (LBD) to indicate which side of the river the various landings, islands, back channels, and other features are located. Because of the twisty nature of the meandering river east bank and west bank have little meaning because the river is rarely flowing north to south! Ditto for state names. This section concerns and Arkansas, Mississippi, and some of Tennessee. But because of channel cutoffs created by the dynamic power of the river as well as the Corps of Engineers' 1933-1942 man-made cutoffs, there are pieces of each state on both sides of the river! We'll also use "left bank" and "right bank" or "left shore" and "right shore" to denote the same. Introduction: Memphis to Helena After exiting the Missouri Bootheel and bouncing along the Chickasaw Bluffs past Memphis, the Mighty Mississippi flows southwesterly in giant meandering loops into the verdant and fantastically fertile Mississippi Delta. This is the land that gave birth to the Delta

Blues, and was once the cotton kingdom of the world. Its forest was America's Amazon, millions of acres of deep woods now removed for farmland. Leaving Tennessee and entering Mississippi the paddler is welcomed by a long line of casinos that rivals Atlantic City, but which you'll see little evidence of as you paddle behind long chains of islands in the same area, although you should stop for a visit to the Tunica Riverpark Museum. The river carves elegant S-curves through deep woods as it meanders through Commerce Bend, Mhoon Bend and Walnut Bend, and then wanders down through a floodplain fifteen miles wide to the mouth of the St. Francis River. The big river engulfs mind-boggling swaths of muddy landscapes as it is forced southerly by the strange geophysical anomaly Crowley's Ridge, which parallels the Mississippi out of Missouri. Buck Island invites exploration, picnicking or camping, and Helena, Arkansas commands the base of Crowley's Ridge, and is the only population in between Memphis and Vicksburg (300 miles) that sits right on the main channel as result. Visit the Delta Cultural Center, or coordinate your adventure with one of the world's greatest celebrations of music, the King Biscuit Blues Festival (October). Canoeists, SUPs and kayakers will find provisions, maps, gear, and paddling tips at Quapaw Canoe Company - Helena, as well as water and Wi-Fi. CLICK HERE for the next section

# Memphis to Tunica

# Memphis to Tunica

*Memphis to Helena — Mile 737-663*

LBD Mile 736 Memphis, Tennessee, Mud Island Harbor https://mapsengine.google.com/map/edit?mid=zuHKMJCfTcpQ.kUYIvKgH8J_0 One of the most memorable experiences along the Lower Mississippi is entering and leaving the city of Memphis, which straddles the 4th Chickasaw Bluff and shimmers like a mirage on the floodplain with its striking landmarks the pyramid, the steel truss Memphis & Arkansas Bridges, and the graceful M-Bridge. The South Bluff is topped by the National Ornamental Metal Museum. This is the ridge and the bridge that Chuck Berry made famous in his song Memphis, Tennessee : “Her home is on the South-side, High upon a ridge, Just a half-a-mile from the Mississippi Bridge...” For the downstream paddler, the route out of Memphis is fairly straightforward. There is no choice but main channel until you reach Dismal Point ten miles downstream. After leaving the Mud Island Harbor stay bank left with the fast water under the bridge and follow it on and around Engineer’s Bar/Presidents Island. This line of travel will put you closer to bankside docks and industry, but well out of the way of uncertain routes and resupply positions used by the big tows passing through this area. There are three openings the three spans of the bridge. As always watch for tows above and below the bridges. Upstream tows typically go middle span while downstreamers use the left span below the South Memphis Bluff. During high water upstreamers might use the far right span closer to the Arkansas shore for the slower waters. The river can sometimes be thick with commercial activity. Resupply and crew boats often tend to the big tows in this vicinity. You might notice a big tow maintaining position mid channel, or maybe slowly moving along. Resupply vessels roar in and out alongside. In addition small tows and work boats frequent several ports including the Exxon Dock, Drexel Chemicals, Scrap Metals, and other industrial sites left bank. Work boats tend to kick up a big wake. Watch for crashing 2-3 foot waves which will be compounded by winds or other passing tows. You might also encounter the Memphis Queen (little wake). Even with the all of the docks and activity the best line of passage is found along left bank descending, staying with the faster deeper waters and out of the myriad unpredictable lines followed by the big tows in the middle of the channel. Buoys and Docks The second most dangerous hazard to any big river paddler is a stationary object in a strong current (first most being towboats and barges). In smaller rivers stationary

hazards include rocks, boulders, trees, snags, bridges, fences, etc. On the big river the main stationary hazards are fleeted barges, but also includes docks, piers, and buoys. You will paddle past many docking facilities found within the three mile busy section below the lower Memphis bridges. Maintain at least a 100 yard safety distance away from these docks, and more if there appears to be any tow activity. Keep in mind that the wind can blow you sideways into bankside hazards. The river currents can also push you laterally across the face of the river. Watch shoreline landmarks and adjust your angle of travel accordingly. If necessary ferry out and head for the middle of the river, or the far side RBD. There are no buoys bank left through this section of river, because the water is deep all the way to the bank. But if your line of travel takes you into the middle of the river you will find a long line of green buoys (tow pilots call them the cans for their cylindrical-shaped tops) marking the far edge of the navigation channel there. Oftentimes they are placed at the ends of wing dams or dikes. And that is indeed normally the case in this bend of the river, the US Coast Guard tries to maintain these buoys in a position of deep water at the ends of what is marked on the map as the Engineer Bar Dikes. How deep is the water at the buoy? Towboats & fully-loaded barges draw nine feet maximum, but to add a little buffer the USCG likes to place them at the twenty foot depth. This helps accommodate changes of water level in the ever fluctuating Mississippi River.

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Floating Underneath a Bridge Floating underneath a bridge is one of the most sensational of Mississippi River experiences. For the paddler on the wide open Mississippi River it's difficult to get a sense of motion, speed, and the river current. Sometimes it feels like you are sitting in a lake not a river, even though you are indeed floating within the throes of the biggest and most powerful river in North America! That is until you pass underneath a bridge. As you scoot downstream the water piles up high against the bridge pylons and then swirls around the backside with violent convulsions and contortions of water, and you will enjoy the distinct sensation of river motion as the bridge abutments mysteriously slide by and the geometric truss work and solid concrete road bed swing overhead with surprising speed, the higher the water the faster the speed. At high water this experience can be slightly disconcerting so fast the bridge slides by with sickening sucking sounds and explosions of agitated water. If you entertained any previous doubt about the power of the big river it will now be forever dashed away! 734.7 Lower

Bridges/Engineer’s Bar Engineer’s Bar is a giant sandbar at low water but quickly disappears as the river rises, and is completely swamped in medium water MG20 with only a few narrow bars clinging to various places along the right bank. Don’t camp here at low water unless you can sleep comfortably through rumbling trains, non-stop interstate traffic and eighteen wheelers flying overhead. No matter which way the wind is blowing you’re going to get noise, caustic aromas and sulfurous carbonaceous outpourings from many nearby sources. Unless it’s dark, continue downstream ten miles and camp on the luxurious sands of the giant Ensley Bar/Dismal Point archipelago. There are actually three bridges all clustered together that from the Lower Bridges of Memphis. Avid Memphis kayaker Joe Royer says he prefers the shape and structure of the Lower Bridges over the more popular M Bridge. When you float under their masses you can’t help up but notice the detailed frame work above and the beautiful stone abutments below. Keep reading below for the history of each bridge. If not interested fast forward to President’s Island. 734.7 The Frisco Bridge It must be a law that any type of architectural structure in Memphis should have more than one name. The Frisco Bridge is no exception. Its original name was The Great Bridge at Memphis. Later that was shortened to “The Memphis Bridge,” and commonly referred to as “The Iron Bridge.” The name was changed again to The Frisco Bridge when the Harahan Bridge was built in 1916. But no matter what name you call it, it is considered one of America's great bridges. The Frisco Bridge was the first bridge built on the lower Mississippi, and the only bridge south of St. Louis when it opened in 1892. Building it was a monumental undertaking. The US Army insisted on a 770 foot clear span for river navigation, and at least 75 feet of vertical clearance under the bridge. The result was that the Frisco Bridge had the longest span of any bridge in the US at this time. In order to secure a building permit, city officials insisted that the bridge somehow would carry pedestrian and buggy traffic as well as trains. Thus the deck was built somewhat wider than would have been required for a single railroad track. As a result, two way buggy traffic was periodically allowed. If a train needed to cross the bridge, wagon and buggy traffic was stopped and cleared from the bridge, and then the train was allowed to cross.

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734.7 The Harahan Bridge This is the only railroad bridge between St. Louis and the Gulf of Mexico that is also used simultaneously by pedestrians and vehicles. It was originally named The Rock Island Bridge and was renamed after James

T. Harahan, the president of Rock Island Railroad who was killed four years before the bridge was completed. Ironically he was killed when his car was hit by an oncoming train. On postcards this bridge is sometimes called The Missouri Pacific Iron Mountain Bridge. Completed in 1916 the bridge was structurally advanced for its time, although 23 workers of the steel company lost their lives during its construction. In 1917 cars and trucks were allowed to use the bridge, single file, driving on a narrow, one way wooden roadway that was suspended on the OUTSIDE of the bridge. There was only a short railing on the outside edge of the road. It wasn't until 1949 when the Memphis-Arkansas Bridge opened, that drivers had a much safer means of crossing to Arkansas. Freight trains continue to use the Harahan Bridge. The main bridge structure is 2,548 feet long. The bridge spans match the lengths of the bridge spans of the older Frisco Bridge. This was required by the US Army Corps of Engineers to ensure that the piers would line up so as not to encroach on the navigation channels. 734.7 The Ghost Bunker On the eastern end of Harahan Bridge is a bunker made of granite whose walls have seen some horrible scenes. This area is said to be haunted. The bunker is now known as The Ghost Bunker or The Strange Room. It sits on the exact spot that Fort Pickering, a Civil War strategic post once stood. It was advertised in the 1800's as a clean jail capable of containing 300 likely young slaves by Nathan B. Forrest, slave trader and Confederate general. The victims of the Yellow Fever epidemics of the 1800s were brought to this area by the hundreds, after their death. Over 70 people have used the bridge at this point as a means of suicide. The infamous room was sealed in the 1970's when a huge supply of dynamite and blasting caps were found by railway workers. However it's still believed that ghost enthusiasts use the old bunker as a ghostly ground-zero to conduct their séances and ghost hunts. They have walked away with audio evidence of screams and unexplained photographic oddities. 734.7 The Old Bridge (Memphis & Arkansas Bridge) This bridge cost $10.5 million and as part of Interstate 55, it connects Arkansas with Tennessee. Unfortunately it was not built to withstand an earthquake and can't be retrofitted with seismic protection. When this bridge opened it meant there were now three bridges at this location - approximately 150 feet apart. The upstream structure is the Harahan Bridge. The Frisco Bridge is the middle structure, and the Memphis-Arkansas Bridge is next in line. As of 2007 the Memphis-Arkansas Bridge continues to serve as a vital automobile conduit for cross-river traffic. It carries 50,000 cars each day - only about 5,000 fewer than the newer Hernando de Soto Bridge to the north.

This bridge has 5 names: Memphis and Arkansas Bridge, Memphis-Arkansas Bridge, Memphis-Arkansas Memorial Bridge, Memphis & Arkansas Memorial Bridge, and now a new name, The Old Bridge. The Memphis-Arkansas Bridge was built in 1949 as part of the US-40. It replaced the narrow traffic lanes that were attached to each side of the Harahan Bridge. It was built before the introduction of the Interstate Highway System, so the span was not built to Interstate standards. It lacked the concrete barrier between the different directions of traffic and they were added later. It was also built with a sidewalk on either side of the roadway. They are also now separated from the traffic lanes by concrete barriers. However sidewalk travel has been prohibited on the bridge. (from Historic-Memphis.com)

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733 President's Island Boiling out Memphis and riding the fast water of the main channel the downstream the canoeist or kayaker will be buoyed increasingly westward and even northwestward by the hulking teardrop shape of President’s Island (which is actually a compound island joined by its sister Vice President's Island). If you were previously battling a south wind in downtown Memphis you will now enjoy some protection from President’s Island, especially if you stay towards the left bank descending. Paradoxically if you were happily riding a north wind through Memphis you will now be faced with a challenging crawl as the currents propel you into side winds and then head winds as the sometimes blustery westerlies or northerlies race across the open river from the open fields of Arkansas and are funneled up through this bend. It’s best to stay off the river if the forecast calls for anything over 25 mph. Remember, head wind speed is increased by the speed of the river (while tail winds are reduced). Side winds can sometimes be the worst. Side winds will make smaller but choppier waves which can accumulate dangerously along the edges of the big boil and eddy lines of the Lower Mississippi and quickly fill and swamp open canoes and kayaks. Kayakers should seal their spray skirts and canoeists should keep bailers ready if paddling in strong side winds. On a river, head winds make bigger swells, but they tend to hit the canoe or kayak in the way that canoe & kayaks are designed to best withstand: from their bow or stern ends. Within two miles below the bridge you will leave the last of industry left bank descending, and you can turn and look back for the last glimpses of the pyramid and downtown Memphis from the unusual perspective seen framed by the Lower Bridges and the south bluff. I love watching the pyramid and the color changes from different perspectives. Like water, its

glassy sides reflect whatever is going on in the sky around it, but changed. Is that the last of the city? Not completely. There is still some right bank activity to come around West Memphis, Arkansas. And the busy mouth of the industrial harbor is eight miles downstream LBD. But for the most part you can relax and enjoy the resumption of bankside forests, sandbars and the wild beauty of the Lower Mississippi. Even the Mid-South’s biggest city is dwarfed by on the floodplain of the Mississippi River. Marion Braggs Historic Names and Places provides some interesting glimpses into the colorful history of President’s Island: “During the latter part of the Civil War, Presidents Island was the site of a refugee camp for more than 1,500 blacks from southern plantations. The Federal agency called the Freedmen's Bureau established the colony but when the Bureau was abolished, the ex-slaves had to learn to take care of themselves. Some of them may have gone to work for Confederate General Nathan B. Forrest, who retired to Presidents Island for a time after the war to manage a large plantation. General Forrest had been a slave trader in Memphis before the war, and so firmly did he discipline his labor force that many of them may have wondered whether the difference between slavery and freedom had been exaggerated. “Many years after the Civil War, a pest house was maintained on Presidents Island. Most southern cities had such crude hospitals, where people with highly contagious diseases could be isolated from the general public. With the pest house and a prison located on the island, respectable people gave it a wide berth until some years later, when it became a sort of gambler's paradise in the 1920's. In January,1924, cock fights on Presidents Island attracted international attention. Birds from Mexico, Cuba, and other countries were matched against each other, and huge sums of money were wagered on the outcome of each gory battle.”

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Fleeted Barges As you are leaving the Memphis Industrial reach, be wary of the rows of fleeted barges ties up alongside either bank, especially in the 2 miles below the lower bridges, in the West Memphis area, and then also in the vicinity of the McKellar Lake Memphis Harbor. What are fleeted barges? When any industrial or agricultural facility are filling or emptying barges, they tie them up along the bank of the river, sometimes one at a time, but more often in longer lines multiple barges deep. Sometimes they're only one barge deep, sometimes they'll tie more than one side-by-side. In chemical corridor down below Baton Rouge they'll sometimes tie as many as a hundred long with ten or twelve deep! Most barges measure 35 x 250 feet but petroleum barges are often longer.

The top end of any fleeted barges is an extremely dangerous place. Always avoid paddling anywhere near the upstream sides of barges -- where the water is pushing in and underneath their top ends. It might look like you could simply hop aboard in case of emergency, but you won't be able to! This is a trick of perspective on the big river. They are much higher off the water than they look. LBD 732 Hole in the Wall #2 As you're paddling downstream look for a gaping opening in the rip-rap LBD which you can paddle through if you so desire. As you approach you will notice that the natural bankside of trees and mud retreats ever further behind an unnatural wall of rip-rap. (At low water the effect is most strongly felt). The river here is trying to eat the left bank, and our engineers are doing their best to keep it from doing so. During the Great Flood of 2011 the main channel tried to carve a new channel through the center of President's Island. If it had been successful it could have destroyed McKellar Lake and the Memphis Industrial Harbor. As of the summer of 2013 a fleet of Army Corps mega-cranes have been busily trying to recreate the lost bank with Limestone rip rap. As result a King-Kong sized blue hole backwater has been created behind a Great Wall of China sized bank of rip rap. You can paddle into this unique feature as you descend the Mississippi along the left bank. They left a giant notch partway down. When you see the opening in the rip-rap dive in. Great place to get out of the wind, or make a quick exit from an approaching squall line or field of choppy towboat waves. Not a true blue hole, the water is nevertheless clearer than the main channel which sometimes provides glimpses of fish, turtles and other creatures not normally seen elsewhere on the river. 727.3 TVA Transmission Lines After rounding President's Island the mile wide main channel narrows in half as it flows into Arkansas and is directed southward in a powerful and sometimes turbulent tongue of water. You can find sandbars along the inside of the bend, but the industry and noise of West Memphis will be your closest neighbor. Keep going five more miles for the best camping in the area, along and below Dismal Point Dikes. Unless there are towboats in the vicinity go with the flow and make your crossing over to Arkansas and stay with the fast water past West Memphis docks and industry which is punctuated by the giant grain elevators of Riceland Foods. Arkansas is the rice bowl of the western hemisphere. It accounts for nearly 46% of total rice produced in the United States. Its nearest competitor California doesn't even come close at 18%.

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After flying past Riceland the channel opens up into an ocean

of possibilities including the harbor opening (LBD 725.5), a wide back channel behind Enlsey/Dismal Point (RBD 725) and the main channel flowing along an archipelago of islands which extend so far downstream and around the next bend that they actually disappear over the curvature of the earth. As you enter this arena of roughshod possibilities you will flow underneath a TVA transmission line which was the site of a life-and-death drama of personal significance. In fact, it was the seminal event of my present life as river guide, author, canoe builder. I probably wouldn't be here today sharing this Rivergator with you if things had gone differently when I first came down the Mississippi in the early 1980s. Please skip forward to the next section if you don't have time for this now. It might make better reading in the tent, or around the campfire, or perhaps best of all waiting until you're safely off the river. I'm going to take a little liberty here and share this tale in full for anyone who cares to hear it. I've never shared this incident in such detail, but now it seems appropriate. There might be a lesson or two within, but mostly it's a tale of fate and foolishness. RBD 727.3 The Wreck of the Raft The Lower Mississippi is a 1,000 mile long graveyard of wrecked vessels and broken hearts. I've added at least one to the pile of wreckage. In February of 1983 the river was seasonally high and cold, and flowing fast, furious even, full of the flotsam and jetsam associated with winter high waters: foam, logs, barrels, bottles, docks, cans, lost barge ropes, and us, a couple of kids on a rugged raft. My best friend from high school Sean Rowe and I had just spent the previous five months on a 12x24 foot raft that we built from found materials and oil drums below the Minnesota bluffs above Lacrosse, Wisconsin. A guy named Shimshak let us build it in his back yard. He had a bar across the river in Lacrosse. Anyone ever been to Shimshak's Tavern? Months earlier we had drawn a crude chessboard with magic markers onto the floor of the raft, and carved the pieces out of willow branches as a way of passing the time. That fateful morning we jumped into a game of chess on board the raft as we floated under the three lower bridges of Memphis. Our chess games passed many long pleasurable miles of the Mississippi. There is nothing more pleasant than the sensation of a raft on a river, floating along effortlessly and enjoying the scenery sliding by with the same comfort of watching a good movie in a lounge chair. Topping off this cozy arrangement was an open fire which we tended in a 55-gallon steel drum cut in half and filled partway with sand. Fire, water, forests, open skies, and a game of chess. What else could you ask for? We were as happy as two catfish in crawdad hole. We were embroiled in one of these legendary raft chess games as we rounded President's Island and rolled

southward in the billowing muddy blossoms of the powerful river. The wind was out of the north. It was sunny and cold, typical February weather. Everything seemed aligned and in our favor. The major difference on the river between then and now is a giant tower planted along the edge of the main channel to support the thick throbbing electrical TVA transmission lines. Standing over three hundred and fifty feet tall, the tower rose above a square of 4 megalithic concrete pylons which were anchored into the bedrock hundreds of feet below river bottom. We sighted the steel truss tower as we came around President's Island, five miles upstream. But we paid it no particular attention, and resumed the game of chess around an open raft fire, sipping cups of hot coffee. Who would worry about one or two pylons in all of that water? The river was high, and probably a mile wide at the time. How are you going to hit anything in a mile-wide river?

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But we did. Fate had a hand in the matter. As we floated along unconcerned and infatuated with our game the river brought us past the grain elevators and smack dab directly into the fast waters plowing into the tower. Only a hundred yards upstream the tower loomed ominously overhead, too close. Much too close! We leapt to action on the sweep oars and pulled like mad. We probably pulled the wrong way. Then again maybe we pulled the right way and it didn’t matter. This raft was very ungainly and slow to propel. On a good day it would take us three hours of pulling to cross the channel. We frustrated the patience of many a lockmaster down the Upper Miss, including one especially impatient fellow who jumped on his go-cart and burned out his engine trying to tow us through! It’s hard to remember now what exactly happened and in what sequence of events. All my memories of that day are like a stream-of-consciousness reel in an avant-garde movie with a hand-held camera that rolls and tumbles through space and time, and then flips over, and then goes completely dark. The river pushed us directly into one of the concrete pillars. I can’t remember now which of the two upstream pillars it was, the right or left, but regardless which one it was, we hit it hard, with so much force we both were both knocked over and everything loose skidded across the deck. The raft had come to a sickening halt, not budging one direction nor the other. We could neither crawl up the rounded wall of concrete, nor could we push the raft away from it. As all paddlers know, the power of water on a vessel trapped in the current against a stationary object is insurmountable except by mechanical means. We experienced more horror as one end of the raft was sucked down, and the

other pushed up the pylon, and all our possessions like our journals and my camera and a 12-string guitar were swept overboard, along with all of the familiar raft comforts that had become our home, the cast iron pots and pans, the barrel fire, the chess pieces, the ropes, the sweep oars, our food supply -- we had just resupplied in Memphis: some chickens, a ten pound bag of potatoes, a bag of onions, cooking oil, eggs, and some jars of peanut butter all lost -- and then we too were tossed into the frigid February waters, and the raft was snapped like a saltine cracker around the base of the pylon where the river hit it, and everything became dark and quiet and cold, and we were sucked down by the alternating vortexes and explosions of the river and it felt like my whole life was passing through me and around me. I've always been attracted to water. As a child growing up in the mountains of Colorado I always sought out a place to splash around and get wet, which wasn't always easy to do. My friends and family thought I'd gone astray when I left the big mountains for the big river of the Lower Mississippi River Valley. But here in the willow-thick riverbanks and deep woods and endless expanses and expressions of pure muddy joy I've found what seems to be my life's calling. It’s the one place where everything makes sense. It’s the one place where I find peace and solace, and many other paddlers and river rats feel the same. It’s the one place where the opposing forces of nature seem to mix in some kind of rough harmony. It’s the one place where heaven comes close to earth. Here on the river, the lifeblood of mother earth. And now fighting for my life submerged into a watery crossroads strung between a major TVA power line and the most powerful river in this quadrant of the earth I could feel the wonderful turbulent surge of creation being edged by an equal awesome force of destruction, the two intertwined and rubbing sides in opposite directions, spinning me round and round, and now my life was in the balance between the two, caught in the tightrope between life and death deep within the violence of the angry winter waters.

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We all have someone in our lives who opened up the door to the wilderness for us. Think on it a minute and thank them for that gift. My parents were outdoor lovers and adventurists, especially my father, but my mother also. They wouldn’t like to think so, but they led me, somehow, to that raft and to this river. I am amazed now when I remember the adventures we had and the great risks they took with us and with their lives. And yet those same risks opened our eyes to a parallel reality that exists just outside the safety of our comfortable homes, just over the riverbank off the highway, back in the woods

beyond the last line of fences and private property signs. My parents would pack my family of ten into our green van and make crazy camping vacations deep into the Baja California or up the Canadian Rockies (where my father family lived) into Alaska. My mother is Colorado born, 5 generations deep. I would have to say that more than anyone my father opened my eyes to the beauty and thrill of the great outdoors... something that was repeatedly carried on through my older brothers who continued to backpack and cross country ski and involve me in the same throughout my childhood. There was something slightly out of control about these family adventures, but that is one of the universal aspects of the wilderness, isn't it? That is, being awestruck and governed by something larger than yourself, something chaotic, which is sometimes frightening, sometimes enlightening. And yet out of the chaos emerges profound beauty and renewal. Anyone who has spent any time on the Mississippi River could easily share those same feelings. At turns frightened and enlightened. If you don't let the fright get the best of you, don't let it transform into paranoia, that helpless feeling that will confine you to the couch, then the shock of fright opens up a pathway to learning. Fear leads to amazement. Amazement becomes wonder. And wonder opens your imagination to the endless possibilities of the universe, which seem to be expressed and re-expressed in infinite varieties of forms here on the restless face of the mightiest of all rivers. My older brothers alternately terrorized and then tantalized me into a soulful love of the outdoors. One of my strongest early memories is my oldest brother Frank holding me by my arms over the lip of the Grand Canyon and grinning devilishly. I knew he wouldn't let me go. At the same time I was unable to hold back the terror of the unknown. I think I was 6 or 7 years old. Later he prodded me down the Bright Angel Trail for a frigid swim in the freezing waters of the Colorado River, and then carried me back out on his shoulders by the light of the full moon. Westerners in general have a different ethic about the outdoors than southerners. I grew up at the edge of Arapaho National Forest in the Front Range of Colorado, which rises from the Great Plains like a tsunami wave, and this was the playground for my friends and family. Everywhere we travelled throughout the Rockies and Desert Southwest we hiked and camped and swam. On road trips when it was time to camp we simply turned off the highway into the nearest National Park and picked out a place. I grew up with the feeling that the outdoors belonged to everyone, not only to those who can afford a hunting camp over the levee. It was much later, when I grew into the difficult teenage years, that I rediscovered my love of water, and became more involved in

its meaning and importance, not only to myself but all Americans, and really to the benefit of all people on the face of this planet. Water connects us all, for better or worse. The wetlands are disappearing at an alarming rate, while floods are becoming more frequent and catastrophic, and seem to be alternating with severe droughts. The recent push to remove the New Madrid Floodway seems absurd in this light. So when Sean and I scuttled any ambitions for higher education (much to the dismay of our college counselors) and instead built our giant wooden raft and floated down the Mississippi River out of the Minnesota woods, it was the start of a journey that resonates loudly today. It saved me. It almost killed me. Five months later when we lost all of our earthly possessions and became shipwrecked on a muddy island in Northern Mississippi, and I became infected for life. I became infected with the muddy river. I was struck by a ray of light that still guides me to this very day and illuminates the way down the difficult dusty road of business and an ever rewarding life as a river-rat.

*[Chapter continues...]*

# Tunica to Helena

# Tunica to Helena

*Memphis to Helena — Mile 737-663*

700 Basket Bar This long series of luxurious sandbars are full of birds and thick with fish -- and broken up into in a long line of wild islands -- and are found opposite the thickest concentration of casinos outside of Vegas and Atlantic City! During higher water levels above 25 Memphis Gauge paddlers can opt for the enjoyment of the back channel. Stay RBD as you pass Finley Bar (Mile 702.8) and follow the back channel a full five or six miles downstream before popping out at Peter’s Bend (Commerce Bend) near Rabbit Island. Paddlers Routes through Commerce and Mhoon Bends: https://maps.google.com/maps/ms?msid= 217859314001592865582.0004e5b96e2db7c41a661&msa=0 http://goo.gl/maps/hPaou Commerce and Mhoon Bends carve a classy S Curve through deep forests and extensive sandbars of the Mississippi Delta, offering great paddling, picnicking, and camping in a wide variety of landscapes, from woods to soft sand to fascinating gravel bars. Main Channel Main Channel is fairly straightforward. Go to the outside of each bend for the fastest waters, follow middle channel out of each bend, and make your crossings with the main outward thrust of water. Watch for tows and strong eddies. Rabbit Island Back Channel In high water go with the blossoming currents bank left across the wide watery expanse as close to the trees as you can find flow. Several miles past Commerce Point you can paddle behind a small forested island through which the channel narrows and gurgles along through stands of submerged willows and cottonwoods before re-entering the main channel a couple of miles above Mhoon Landing. Mhoon Bar Back Channel At high water you can stay tight bank right as you exit Commerce Bend, and swirl around the last big eddy at Ashley Point, and then follow the receding line of trees downstream. Watch sharp for bankside beaver and treetop bald eagles (which are known to next in this area). There is a hump of sand bottom end topped with willows and cottonwoods. Paddle behind these and back out into the main channel.

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695-690 Commerce Bend Right angle bend running westward and then south slightly eastward around Rabbit Island. Commerce Bend is as good as any in demonstrating the dynamic and irascible nature of the big muddy river in a big muddy landscape. Commerce, Mississippi, had a hopeful beginning and was a thriving little river town in the 1830's,

but by 1841 it was engauged in a losing battle with the Lower Mississippi, and it soon lost most of its waterfront buildings and houses. In 1874 the Mississippi jumped across a neck of land just below Commerce and cut about ten miles off its channel. Local people reported that a steamboat passed through the new cutoff just two days after the river changed its course, and that it was 800 yards wide by the third day. The river continued making changes around Commerce, causing all kinds of trouble for the little town and doing a lot of damage to property in the area. It finally settled itself comfortably in a new bed known as Mhoon Bend, where it still remains today- restrained from further movement by a long revetment on the east bank of the bend. The steamboat landing at Commerce was still in occasional use as late as 1888, when a boat called the Kate Adams caught fire and burned at the landing. The big side-wheel boat was one of the first steamers on the Lower Mississippi to be completely equipped with a modern invention known as the electric light. The popular boat was also noted for the beauty of its cabin accommodations. The staterooms were paneled in solid walnut, cherry, and ash. The town of Commerce was still hanging on in 1915, and still had a post office and steamboat landing, but the river had built up a big sandbar in front of it. As the steamboat trade on the river dwindled away, the community gradually disappeared. (Adopted from Bragg’s Historic Names & Places ) But fortune has many twists and turns along its convoluted route. Today Commerce has been rejuvenated by a cluster of casinos just over the levee from the old town site, which is now occupied by a MicroHotel, a Quality Inn, and an Exxon gas station at the corner of Casino Strip Resort Blvd and Perry Rd. There is no present connection to the river save for a short revetment above Rabbit Island called Commerce Revetment. This history would be worthy of another Robert Johnson blues, had he lived long enough to pen more songs. He is reported to have resided for a year at the nearby Abbey & Leatherman Plantation. RBD 692.5 Peter's Boat Ramp Narrow rugged revetment ramp laid over the rip rap. Usable at all water levels, but long overland drive for access to any conveniences, at least 20 miles to Marianna. For resupply keep going to Helena, 29 miles downstream.

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690 Rabbit Island Great camping at all but the highest water levels. For paddlers on the main channel Rabbit Island seems to go on forever, especially with a head wind. During high water you can cut the corner. As the river approaches flood stage the back channel swells open a “country-mile-wide”

offering paddlers a welcome alternative to the sometimes very busy main channel, which gets squeezed at the base of Rabbit Island. In high water go with the blossoming currents bank left across the wide watery expanse as close to the trees as you can find flow. Several miles past Commerce Point you can paddle behind a small forested island through which the channel narrows and gurgles along through stands of submerged willows and cottonwoods before re-entering the main channel a couple of miles above Mhoon Landing. During low water the sandbar becomes the size of the Sahara Desert with endless locations for swimming and beach combing, the best is saved for last: a long slender sandy peninsula forms between the flowing muddy river and a giant lake-sized clear water inlet behind, affording spectacular beaches and inspiring close up views of upstream tows. There are two signed channel markers around the Island (along the outside of Commerce Bend) that are conveniently placed almost exactly two miles apart. With a watch in hand you can get an approximate reading of the river speed. During the high-water of 1979 I clocked a startling 12mph at this location, and found the same two bends downstream in Walnut Bend. Local music legend John Mohead had dropped me off early that morning in Memphis and by dark I was under the Helena Bridge and made landing at Montezuma above Friars Point, after having paddled 83 miles in about 10 hours. John James Audubon reported seeing bear running across Rabbit Island during his 1820 descent of the Lower Mississippi River. His journey exposed the wildlife of the South to his fine artistic capabilities, most of which he would shoot first and paint later. Switching to the Helena gage Mhoon Landing is 25 miles above Helena, For the remainder of this Rivergator section we will refer to the Helena gage (HG) . This guide will try and describe all important landings and islands and openings to lakes using three water levels, low water, medium water and high water. The next designation would be flood stage (FS) or above. This guide will make few if any descriptions of anything on the Mississippi at or above flood stage. This guide will make strong recommendations for not paddling on the Mississippi at or above flood stage. Referring to the Helena gage (HG): Low Water = -6 to 20 HG Medium Water = 21 to 35 HG High Water = 36 to 43 HG Flood Stage = 44 HG and above Warning: above 44 HG paddlers are advised to stay off the river. Limited access. Most landings and approach roads will be underwater. Most islands will be gone. No easy camping. All sandbars will be covered. Fast waters with many hazards. All islands and landings will be surrounded by flooded forests full of snags, strainers, sawyers and all other dangerous conditions associated with floodwater

moving through trees. Docks, wharves, dikes and any other man-made objects will create strong whirlpools, violent boils, and fast eddies. Towboats will create large waves. The Rivergator will not describe the river and its islands at any levels above flood stage.

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Dikes and Water Levels In the Tunica-Helena-Clarksdale area you can use the following scale to gauge water flowing over dikes, although some dikes vary in height. Also some have been “notched” in recent years as result there will be a middle notch that you can paddle through at much lower levels of water, some places down to 10 on the Helena Gauge. Dike exposure using the Helena Gauge: 10-17HG water flowing through notches only 18HG rocks still exposed on all dikes 18-22 dikes starting to go under, some flow through breaks & low spots 23 dikes completely under, but little flow 25-29HG good flow and lots of boils & turbulence 30HG strong flow, turbulence, no dikes exposed anywhere 35HG river bank full >44HG Flood Stage. Warning: above 44 MG paddlers are advised to stay off the river. Limited access. Most landings and approach roads will be underwater. Most islands will be gone. No easy camping. All sandbars will be covered. Fast waters with many hazards. All islands and landings will be surrounded by flooded forests full of snags, strainers, sawyers and all other dangerous conditions associated with floodwater moving through trees. Docks, wharves, dikes and any other man-made objects will create strong whirlpools, violent boils, and fast eddies. Towboats will create large waves. The Rivergator will not describe the river and its islands at any levels above flood stage. 687.5 Mhoon Landing Rough revetment landing with paved access to Tunica and Highway 61. Popular party spot. Don’t leave your vehicle overnight. County park just beyond with bathrooms. Possible camping, but expect company, usually of the friendly sort. Ten mile walk into town. If you need to resupply Helena is your best option, 25 miles downstream. Landing bottoms out in low water. Parking lot goes under at flood stage. Mhoon Landing is the location of the infamous Splash Casino, the pioneer Tunica County establishment that charged $10 just to enter and game, and had three hour waiting lines when it first opened! Such was the raving popularity for gaming amongst the “live like there’s no tomorrow” Delta crowd! Gambling has a long tradition on the river that spans many generations and enjoyed its heyday in the Steamboatin’ era when every paddle wheeler boarded hucksters, gamers, charlatans, and tricksters of every sort. This lifestyle is detailed in Herman Melville’s little-known novel The Confidence Man , of which list of

characters displays if nothing else the amazing variety of people connected by the waters of the big river, here including the mute, the man with the weed, the gentleman with gold sleeve-buttons, the charitable lady, the unfortunate man, the man with the traveling-cap, the old miser, the sick man, the Herb-Doctor, the soldier of fortune, the one who may be remembered, the hard case, the Tusculan, the Missourian, the philanthropist, the misanthrope, the China Aster, the Cosmopolitan, the man of questionable morality, the Press, the mystical master, the disciple, and many others (caps from Melville).

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689-685 Mhoon Bar You can find good camping on Mhoon Bar (at the inside of Mhoon Bend) at almost any water level up to flood stage. At low and medium water levels camp anywhere you see a good spot around the entire four-mile perimeter. In high water the choices narrow to the last prominent hump of sand (near RBD 686) makes a terrific campsite with mature willows, cottonwoods and sycamores standing tall above for protection. At high water you can cut the corner by staying tight bank right as you exit Peter's Bend (the bend above Mhoon Bar), and swirling around the last big eddy at Ashley Point, and then following the receding line of trees downstream. This will cut several miles off your distance, and also bring you close to the wildlife. Watch sharp for bankside beaver and treetop bald eagles (which are known to nest in this area). Paddle behind the isolated hump of mature trees (described above) which becomes a separate island at higher water levels, and then return to main channel. 690-683 Mhoon Bend Leaving Mhoon Landing the downstream paddler riding the outside of the bend needs to be wary of a very turbulent eddy about a mile and half downstream near LBD 686.5. Below medium water you will see a lot of fresh rip rap where the Army Corps has been trying to stabilize this gnarly place. Ride the channel side of the eddy for a dizzying look at the exploding boils whirlpools and the ricochet speed eddy revolving fast upstream. Locals know this raucous water feature as the "Whirlpool" and it is reputed to be the scene of more than one river drama. I personally got the nose of my canoe stuck in the top end of this place and almost got flipped over when we re-entered the fast main channel. In the front of my canoe was a Seattle reporter getting a ride he was not expecting on the misnamed "Old Man River!" At the height of the 2011 flood the Mississippi River tore over the banks along Mhoon Bend upending trees and houses and went roaring through the woods to spill back over into Tunica Lake, which is a couple of miles south. Tunica Lake swelled accordingly

with muddy brown water and flooded every house in the collection of fishing and hunting camps located on its northeast corner. This Tunica Lake Community is a lively enclave of rednecks and river rats who fondly call themselves “The Cutoff.” The resilient Cutoff folks rebuilt after the flood, some adding a little elevation to what they had before 2011, and others throwing all care to the wind and rebuilding exactly the same. In modern times, there has been some local effort to refer to the Cutoff as “Tunica Lake” since it sounds more dignified, and the “Cutoff” had gotten a bit of a bad name as a place where non locals hung out – many to drink and carry on. 682-679 Whiskey Chute/Walnut Bend The main channel slows down momentarily as it exits Mhoon Bend and slides into Whiskey Chute where the banks open up to almost a mile wide. It’s a lovely piece of river with tall trees on either side. Your best route of descent is staying with the current left bank past a series of dikes at the top end LBD of Walnut Bend. At low water pristine pools (blue holes) of clear water are formed in the downstream side of the topmost dikes. Sometimes these blue holes grow to the size of an Olympic swim pool, and are filled with delightful dancing blueish/greenish water. Other times they become diminished with murky green-black water and mud slip bottoms inhabited by turtles and minnows and who knows what else. As you get deep in the bend you can hug the inside LBD and cut the corner (where excellent low/med water camping can be found, but none at high water). Or you can go wide with the fastest water, and get the slingshot treatment as the river pushes you outwards with centrifugal force and you quickly find yourself on the opposite shore. Not a good time or place to meet an upstream towboat! The turbulent waters here are known to respond exponentially with the passage of upstream tows. I remember paddling with a Chattahoochee River guide in one of my big 26 foot long voyageur canoes into some choppy tall waves being ejected in the outwash of a big upriver tow at this place. This guide is a friend of mine and he still laughs at the experience. He was not expecting waves on the Mississippi. The 3-screw tow passed up into Walnut Bend and on purpose we entered the wave train skyrocketing downstream behind his tail in a series of tall standing waves that were more tight than usual in formation. Some of the waves were breaking by the time we got to the highest and darkest swells in this series. My friend’s eyes got big. And then he stopped paddling, maybe out of some reflex of self-preservation. In shock he put his paddle down and held onto the gunnels of the canoe as the bow rose six, seven, maybe eight feet above the stern, and then clapped downwards with a mighty splash that rolled over the waist of the bow paddler and wetted the first

three rows of paddlers behind. It was my friend’s first time on the Mississippi and he has been hooked since!

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At higher water levels you can stay right bank descending into Walnut Bend and duck behind a small isolated island built up within the Walnut Bend Dikes near RBD 681. After sliding back out of this short channel you will be less than a mile from the St. Francis River, which has meandered into the vicinity of the big river, and then meanders outward, and continues on curving downstream another 21 miles before its junction with the mother Mississippi (only 7 miles by the big river). You might want to make a landing here and walk through the woods and climb to the top of the levee and see the sluggish St. Francis beyond over some fields. Along the way you will walk through several depressions in the forest floor. These low places are the remnants of some geomorphologic shaping that occurred when the Mississippi tried to jump channel and make a new confluence of the St. Francis River during the Great Flood of 1927 (known as the Whitehall Crevasse). It makes for an interesting side trip, but be sure to secure your canoe or kayak well above wave splash height along the bank before doing so, especially at low water when the passing tows will slam it against the sharp stones of the rip-rap. 680 Whitehall Crevasse The rampaging Mississippi broke through at Whitehall on April 15, 1927, and the gap enlarged rapidly until it was 2,400 feet wide, The St. Francis River flows within a mile of the Lower Mississippi in the vicinity of Whitehall, and the great crevasse very nearly allowed the two rivers to come together in a new confluence many miles above the normal mouth of the little tributary. The Whitehall crevasse occurred so unexpectedly that many people living in the area affected had to take refuge in trees and on housetops. Some of them had to wait several days on their uncomfortable perches for rescue. There were 13 major crevasses in 1927, and official reports estimated that 330,000 persons had to be rescued from trees and housetops. Before the flood had ended, 700,000 people had to leave their homes. (Braggs: Historic Names ) Paddler’s routes below Walnut Bend: Stumpy Island, Shoo Fly Bar and Tunica Lake https://maps.google.com/maps/ms?msid=217859314001592865582.0004e5d0230125ad128fd&msa=0&ll=34.686581,-90.549831&spn=0.169384,0.368042 http://goo.gl/maps/VjHqN The paddler has a couple of enticing routes to follow below Walnut Bend, with Shoo Fly on one side of the channel and Stumpy Island on the other and a fantastic side-trip option into Tunica Lake. Main Channel Follow the main channel of the river bouncing back and forth in between

Shoo Fly Bar, Harbert Point and Stumpy Island. The St. Francis River confluence is two miles below Stumpy Island. Tunica Runout LBD 677.4 The Tunica Runout is a dynamic three-and-a-half mile long passage connecting the big river and the giant oxbow Tunica Lake. Enter deep woods east off the river and paddle over rock weir 1/4 mile upstream of mouth (passable above 10HG). Channel curves increasingly southward several miles and then enters Tunica Lake through descending lines of willows. Paddle as far as you feel like going then turn around and paddle back. Behind Shoo Fly Bar During low water you can stay LBD and make short foray behind the ethereal creamy yellow sands of Shoo Fly. One of the rare back channels flowing during low water.

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Stumpy Island Follow RBD route below Walnut Bend two miles and during high water paddle behind the small island with a short chute behind. Excellent picnicking or camping can be found all water levels. Walnut Bend Boat Ramp Functional but primitive boat ramp located in a strategic place right bank descending at the bottom of Walnut Bend. Partly revetment, partly gravel, partly rock. Located on the Arkansas bank on the edge of a giant eddy. Tunica Lake Boat Ramp Public Boat Ramp on Northeast corner of lake off Charlie Lane in the Tunica Cutoff Community. Wide concrete ramp with safe parking. Thirteen mile flat-water paddle through the Runout to reach the open river. RBD 679 Walnut Bend Boat Ramp (AKA Battle Axe Boat Ramp) A functional but primitive boat ramp located in a strategic place right bank descending at the bottom of Walnut Bend. Partly revetment, partly gravel, partly rock. Located on the Arkansas bank on the edge of a giant eddy. Those needing to make landing can swirl around the eddy and pull back to bank with the circular motion. Those headed out from the landing can put in and follow the flow back upstream to where the opposing waters meet at the edge of the eddy and dive into the strong downstream current wherever an inviting opening shows itself. Note: try to wait until you see an outpouring of water into the big water, maybe around a small whirlpool. It will make the entry into the main channel much easier. It is approximately a ten mile walk, mostly on the gravel top of the Arkansas levee, to the nearest town (Marianna). Three miles down the levee you will cross the St. Francis River at the Huxtabee Pumping Station. This freshwater pumping station was very busy during the flood of 2011. When the Mississippi River rises they shut the gates down and close off the St. Francis to prevent back flooding. As the waters of the St. Francis backs up behind the Arkansas levee they turn a switch and ignite the Huxtabee to pump the

water back over the levee. Such are the complications of families, farms and floodplains in the Mississippi Delta. 679-677 Hardin Cut-Off The main channel of the Mississippi explodes out of Walnut Bend and into a five mile southerly run through Hardin Cut-Off towards the mouth of the St. Francis. Here you will get your first views of Crowley's Ridge, which meets the Mississippi at Helena. The faint line of trees in the far distance a little higher than the rest is the top of the ridge. It's an impressive view with the river bouncing back and forth in between Shoo Fly Bar, Harbert Point and Stumpy Island. The St. Francis confluence is just below Stumpy Island.

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Hardin was the final cutoff in a ten-year river shortening campaign started in 1929 that resulted in 14 man-made cutoffs between Memphis and Red River Landing (above Baton Rouge). In the course of a river history it forms increasingly rounded bends which curve back towards one another at their bases like a snake squirming through the sand, and eventually the narrow necks of land separating the two bends breaks through. Man can speed up the process by digging across one of the necks. Here a giant bend of the river known as OK Bend had eaten everything but a one-mile piece of dry land. A canal was dug through the forest bottoms here during low water 1941-42. When the final plug of land was blown out on March 18, 1942 the turbulent muddy river immediately poured through the opening and tore open the wooded landscape hundreds of acres at a time, not stopping to wipe her mouth or take a deep breath until her appetite was completely satisfied. By May 27th it was open and stable for towboat navigation, the river having been shortened by ten miles and Tunica Lake now preserved in time by rocks, rip-rap and revetment over the banks to the east. In the matter of two months hunting camps near the little river town of Austin, Mississippi, went from enjoying a commanding view of the lively main channel and all its traffic to becoming a remote backwater hamlets surrounded by forest on one side and a huge still-water lake on the other. Austin itself was separated from the Mississippi years ago by shifting islands, one of which was the scene of the Pennsylvania tragedy of 1858. If you need to get on downstream and make some miles stay with the fast water main channel and enjoy the engaging view in the constantly changing juxtaposition of islands, forested points, back channels, openings, and the high ridge beyond. But if you have a little time and want to do some exploring in a spectacular location that is always thriving with some kind of life form stay bank left and look for an intriguing opening into the deep woods two miles below the bottom of Walnut Bend.

This is the legendary Tunica Runout. Tunica Lake: Deep in the woods opposite Hardin Cut-Off is the old channel of “OK Bend” where Mark Twain’s brother, Henry Clemens, met his demise after the explosion & sinking of the steamboat The Pennsylvania (1858). Mark Twain would have been on the same boat but was saved by a simple twist of fate that grounded him in New Orleans before departure. The only route for paddlers to gain access to this bend of the river (which is now a giant isolated oxbow lake known as Tunica Lake) is through the Tunica Runout. Keep reading below. LBD 677.4 (Pass into Tunica Lake) The Tunica Runout slices a two hundred yard wide meandering canyon three-and-a-half miles through the thick trees and mud to reach Tunica Lake. (Note: In general, most river bends cut off from the River are described as a “cutoff” with the ditch or passage that connects them to the River known as a “runout” or a “pass”). At high water stay hard left because you might scoot right past it. At low water you can be a little more casual. The left bank cottonwood forest descends slightly and gives way to willows, and then opens up to reveal the narrow channel disappearing into the mature bottomland hardwood forests beyond. The forests are deep here, the floodplain is almost fifteen miles wide, ten miles to the east to get to the levee behind Tunica Lake, and five miles to the west to reach the base of the Crowley’s Ridge. At high flood stage this entire fifteen-mile wide basin will be full of flowing water, something most recently demonstrated in May, 2011.

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A rock weir was installed several hundred feet up from the river to hold water in the lake. The Tunica Runout opens over the weir at 14 feet on the Helena Gauge (HG). Below 14HG you will have to portage to get to the lake beyond. Below 0 HG you won’t be able to reach the weir at all by canoe or kayak, but you can dock your vessel at the mouth and walk in. According to local expert Rick Howe the “top of weir is at about 8 MG or about 14HG and there is notch in the weir about 20 ft wide with base at 6MG or about 12HG. Same effect as rock dike with water flowing over it….not advised to cross it or enter the notch. If stable…OK. Portaging around it is a bugger since banks are really snotty and steep, so only route is over it. Rocks and concrete can be treacherous. I’ve never tried it but not sure I would want to.” The runout is a dynamic three-and-a-half mile long passage connecting the big river and the giant oxbow Tunica Lake. As a true pass it can reverse directions depending on river conditions. In a rising river the water flows in, and in a falling river the opposite. The faster the change in river level the faster the water responds

in the pass. In extreme river changes (more than 2 feet a day) a strong current can be expected, and sometimes whitewater conditions are found at the weir. As the river rises above 10 HG the water begins pouring into the lake in a falls over the weir. By 15 the weir is completely submerged and turbulence can be encountered. Above 20 the turbulence lessens and by 25 there is smooth laminar flow into the lake. The reverse is true in a falling river; the water will begin cascading over the weir around 15. In a fast falling river watch out for a big drop between 10 and 15HG. Sometimes a challenge to paddle against, these same in-and-out powerful currents keep the Tunica Runout open and free for passage. Self-dredging. Self-supportive. Self sufficient. Around 35 the river here is bank full and the runout becomes a long channel meandering through a flooded forest, for the paddler an experience bordering on the sublime. The Runout becomes a vibrant reflecting pool for the trees, the sky and everything contained therein. On a bad day you will be uplifted, on a good day you might find ecstasy. Everything seems perfectly balanced between heaven and earth. The scenery is beautiful and the wildlife spectacular. There is always something going on. Numerous game trails cross the pass, predominantly those of the white tailed deer, but also wild hogs, raccoon, and coyotes. Beaver are common, and river otter sometimes seen. Black bear are infrequently reported, and there are rumors of cougar, none verified. But if the elusive red panther is going to be found anywhere in the south, this floodplain this sure feels like the place! Ditto for the ivory billed woodpecker. Pileated woodpeckers are frequently seen crossing from side to side, red-headed woodpeckers, and dozens of other bird species. Red winged blackbirds love the flooded woods closer to the lake, especially during their late fall and early spring migrations, and of course great blue herons and white egrets are common, but to a lesser extent the green heron. In the colder months giant flocks of white pelicans and double breasted cormorants frequent the open lake beyond the pass along with coot and numerous ducks.

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677-676 Shoo Fly Bar Shoo Fly is what paddlers have come to name a dynamic low-lying open bar that forms below the Tunica Runout and is only visible in low water conditions, and goes completely under around 20HG. Paddlers should avoid camping here except in the most perfect of conditions. To be caught in the wind or an oncoming storm here would be like being caught out in the middle of the ocean. Good rest stop or picnic place. Back channel flowing even in the lowest of water. I have found plenty of flowing water as low as -5HG, enough

for canoes, kayaks, SUPs or other shallow draft vessels. Shoo Fly is the last remnant of land leftover from the Hardin Cut-Off which created Tunica Lake in 1942. Local river expert Rick Howe: “This bar was not present prior to about 1995 or so – I used to go the River from Lake through runout and back on stages down to 1 or 2MG. About 1993 or 1995, major flood pushed/translated a huge sand bar in front of the runout and it actually damned up the runout and held Tunica Lake/Cut-Off at about 6MG for a couple of years. Then the next year, it disappeared…moved on down the River pushed by the River currents. Haven’t seen big bar there in years. You mentioned current behind the bar….I suppose this is at very low levels (below 5HG, or so)? Haven’t been there at such low levels…. (We are now seeing -7MG or about -1 or -2HG...) I actually always thought “Shoo Fly Bar” was the historic name of the natural bar on the pre-Cutoff inside bend of the River at what is now the Runout chute… However, Shoo Fly Bar is not a bad/inappropriate name for a big sand bar that forms up at this location in the present River...” 677-674 Stumpy Island Three mile long island (at low water) topped with a young willow/cottonwood/sycamore forest with beautiful camping all around. In high water levels best camping is found top end above the trees, and there is ample water flowing through the back channel. (Cutoff resident Rick Howe recalled catching over 100 bass in one outing 20 years ago, and has not caught another single bass there since!) As the water drops sandbars emerge on all sides and the back channel dries. By low water, around 15HG there is no flow in the back channel and generous sandbars are found on all sides, especially above the island and along main channel. Only when the river bottoms out below zero on the Helena Gauge is the full three-mile length of this island revealed, now attached to the mainland woods along the right bank. 674.5 Harbert Point Swift currents past the point will carry the downstream paddler quickly into the final approach to the mouth of the St. Francis River. You can stay left bank and duck behind the St. Francis Bar. Or you can stay main channel and enjoy a quick view upstream the St. Francis into the heart of Crowley’s Ridge. Take a moment, if you have the time, and eddy out at the mouth of the St. Francis, and enjoy the change in water color, the narrow mouth of the river (several hundred yards) and the common wildlife and river rat sightings. Bald eagles frequent this area, and fishermen, both attesting to the prolific fishery.

*[Chapter continues...]*

# Helena to Friars Point

# Helena to Friars

*Memphis to Helena — Mile 737-663*

661.6 Helena Bridge (Hernando DeSoto Bridge -- US Hwy 49) This is the only bridge in between Memphis and Greenville, over 200 miles of river. Such is the nature of the Lower Mississippi, and what makes this water trail such an attractive adventure for wilderness paddlers. The wildness of the Lower Mississippi River is reflected by the fact that there are so few crossings. Paddlers: aim for whichever bridge opening is not occupied by towboat traffic and stay away from the pylons. “Look both ways before crossing.” Downstream Tows might be approaching from behind Buck Island still hidden from your view. Monitor channel 13 on your VHF Marine radio. If in doubt announce yourself and ask any pilot in the area for recommendations. In general the left-most opening LBD is the least used, hence safest opening, but it’s a long paddle from the Harbor opening. The fastest water flows through the right-hand opening RBD. This is also the most traffic-prone opening due to the many industrial docking facilities, fleeting, towboat and support boat activity found along the Arkansas shore RBD. Floating underneath a bridge is one of the most sensational of Mississippi River experiences. For the paddler on the wide open Mississippi River it’s difficult to get a sense of motion, speed, and the river current. Sometimes it feels like you are sitting in a lake not a river, even though you are indeed floating within the throes of the biggest and most powerful river in North America! That is until you pass underneath a bridge. As you scoot downstream the water piles up high against the bridge pylons and then swirls around the backside with violent convulsions and contortions of water. You will enjoy the distinct sensation of river motion as the bridge abutments mysteriously slide by and the geometric truss work and solid concrete road bed swing overhead with surprising speed, the higher the water the faster the speed. At high water this experience can be slightly disconcerting so fast the bridge slides by with sickening sucking sounds and explosions of agitated water. If you entertained any previous doubt about the power of the big river it will now be forever dashed away! Note: the bridge pylon is a very dangerous place for any paddler, regardless of river level. Keep at least twenty-boat lengths away from it (~100 yards), and never try to enter the eddying waters below. Passing towboats will make any already agitated places like the waters surrounding a bridge pylon to react even more violently 663 RBD Leaving Helena Harbor Leaving the Helena Harbor and heading downstream: As you push from the Helena Harbor and paddle

downstream you will enjoy some of the industrial works of mankind that line the busy channel for several miles below the bridge. See below for writing and recommendations about getting under the Helena Bridge. As you continue downstream past the bridge a long line of docking facilities and industrial installations are found bank right. Paddlers will want to keep a wide buffer zone of safety between your line of travel and any fleeted barges, any docks, piers, or anything else anchored or stationary in the current. If you inadvertently slide into the piers of a dock in these powerful waters you will likely be capsized. Two miles downstream of the bridge the Arkansas Power & Light Dock at 659.4 RBD will be your final industrial hazard until you reach Friars Point.

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Fleeted Barges What are fleeted barges? When any industrial or agricultural facility are filling or emptying barges, they tie them up along the bank of the river, sometimes one at a time, but more often in longer lines multiple barges deep. Sometimes they're only one barge deep, sometimes they'll tie more than one side-by-side. In chemical corridor down below Baton Rouge they'll sometimes tie as many as a hundred long with ten or twelve deep! Most barges measure 35 x 250 feet but petroleum barges are often longer. The top end of any fleeted barges is an extremely dangerous place. Always avoid paddling anywhere near the upstream sides of barges -- where the water is pushing in and underneath their top ends. It might look like you could simply hop aboard in case of emergency, but you won't be able to! This is a trick of perspective on the big river. They are much higher off the water than they look. They might seem innocuous since they aren't moving, and they're tied to shore -- but voyageurs beware! Fleeted barges create one of paddler's worst nightmares: paddling or being pushed (by big boils or strong winds) under the front of a line of fleeted barges. Several years ago a yacht lost power and was pushed sideways into a line of fleeted barges that was nosing upstream along the main channel near Tom Lee Park in downtown Memphis. The boat was immediately flipped over and 3 out 5 people did not return. If this happened to a full-sized yacht, you can imagine what would happen to a canoe -- and did happen. Keep reading. Another tragedy: a pair of canoeists had paddled 2,000 miles from Lake Itasca, Minnesota, and were looking forward to completing their expedition in New Orleans when strong winds pushed them into and then under a wide line of fleeted barges down below Baton Rouge. They were never seen again. Small Tows in Harbors The primary hazard to paddlers on the Lower Mississippi is the one powering

through the current -- the towboats. Smaller “docking” towboats tied up in waiting look innocent but be constantly vigilant for un-announced push-offs. Smaller tows from Helena Marine are often busy in this section moving barges in and out of grain or oil docking, fleeting barges, and performing other necessary maintenance. You might see them suddenly run out off shore to service a passing tow. While big tows will make high rolling wakes immediately behind the tow, these small tows can sometimes create rough wakes with steep and crashing bow waves that will persist for hundreds of yards lateral to the vessel. Even if a small towboat is on the other side of the river, be vigilant for bow waves. Unlike the slow, predictable and ponderous motions of the big tows, the small ones can charge around docking facilities erratically and make quick changes of direction. It’s never safe to assume anything about tow traffic. Conditions are constantly changing and require changing tactics. Your best procedure is to be constantly “on watch” and respond accordingly. Monitor VHF Marine radio Channel 13, and if appropriate announce your presence and intended line of travel. (Note: harbor facilities and docking facilities sometimes use channel 12 or other VHF channels. Inquire locally if you need to communicate).

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Buoys and other Stationary Objects The 2nd most dangerous hazard to any river paddler is a stationary object in a strong current. In smaller rivers stationary hazards include rocks, boulders, trees, snags, bridges, fences, etc. On the big river the main stationary hazards are fleeted barges, but also include docks, piers, and buoys. You will paddle past many docking facilities found within the three mile busy section below the Helena Bridge. Maintain at least a 100 yard safety distance away from these docks, and more if there appears to be any tow activity. Keep in mind that the wind can blow you sideways into bankside hazards. The river currents can also push you laterally across the face of the river. Watch shoreline landmarks and adjust your angle of travel accordingly. If necessary ferry out and head for the middle of the river, or the far side LBD. There are no buoys bank right through this section of river, because the water is deep all the way to the bank. But if your line of travel takes you into the middle of the river you will find a long line of red buoys (tow pilots call them the “nuns” for cone-shaped tops) marking the far edge of the navigation channel there. Oftentimes they are placed at the ends of wing dams or dikes. And that is indeed normally the case in this bend of the river; the US Coast Guard tries to maintain these buoys in a position of deep water at the ends of what is marked on the map as the “Montezuma Bar Dikes.”

How deep is the water at the buoy? Towboats & fully-loaded barges draw nine feet maximum, but to add a little buffer the USCG likes to place them at the twenty foot depth. This helps accommodate changes of water level in the ever fluctuating Mississippi River. Highlights of Civilization Some of the highlights of civilization as you paddle out of Helena include Quincy Soybean Docks (663), Isle of Capri Casino (662), the Helena Bridge (661.8), Texas Eastern (Petroleum) Products (662), Helena Bridge Terminal (661.6), Helena Fuel and Harbor Service (661.5), the Helena Power Plant, the high voltage transmission line of Arkansas Power & light (659.9 -- towboat pilots refer to as the “High Wire”), Texas Gas Trans Corp (Pipeline going under river at 658.7) the Helena Slackwater Harbor (652.2), the Helena wastewater drainage pipes (652), and the ADM/McAlister Grain & Mississippi Limestone (652). All are in Arkansas RBD with the exception of the Casino and the Friars Point locations, which are both in Mississippi LBD. Nature lovers -- do not despair! -- you will soon be leaving all signs of mankind behind. This eleven-mile section (to just below Friars Point) is just a little taste of some “busy-ness” before the wilderness. The good stuff is coming once you get below Friars Point. Furthermore this industrial section is actually a great education and should be looked upon as so. What you see in these eleven miles explains Louisiana’s “Chemical Corridor” and the vast inland port of Greater New Orleans -- and the river’s connection to the world market. This will make a well-rounded tour for the long-distance paddler setting out from Helena down the Water Trail. You get the opportunity to experience a little industry and a lot of nature. The river is both commerce and wilds. It has always been this way since the Athabaskans first migrated across the Bering Strait and then South out of Canada and began ferrying goods along the plentiful river valleys in hollowed logs. They were of course later followed by their descendants the Chickasaw, Choctaw, Quapaw, Natchez, and many others in dugout canoes, hide-covered canoes and bark canoes. The Mississippi is and has always been this continent’s greatest highway and simultaneously also one of its greatest wildernesses. Can the two co-exist? I believe so and will describe it as so.

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The story of the Mississippi and its importance to the heart of America -- and its connections to the rest of the world -- could not be understood without seeing the monuments of mankind. As the river leaves Helena you can see examples of how it cooperates with the ambitions of modern man’s industry & transportation, and then how it seamlessly slips into its mighty

realm of wilderness below where nature predominates. Pollution within the Helena Industrial Reach In 1992, an Americans rivers study of the Lower Mississippi River Helena received a bad report card, the worst Mississippi River Polluter between Memphis and Vicksburg, annually dumping some 76 million tons of nasty stuff. Hopefully this has gotten better in the past 2 decades. At the very least there is less offending industry with the closing of a major chemical plant and a rubber plant that used to operate along the Helena waterfront. While devastating to the local economy, the closing of these industries certainly made for a cleaner river downstream. Can clean industry and a clean river coexist? This is the hope of any paddler and should be the goal of every conscientious board of directors. Any industry respectful of the guidelines of the 1972 Clean Water Act should be able to operate harmoniously with the generosity of the Father of Waters. Unless forced by high winds or bad weather you won't want to camp on any of the small sandbars found between the Mile 663 Helena Harbor and Mile 655 Montezuma Island. Noise, light pollution, and any nasty stuff still being dumped by Phillips County industry being the chief reasons to keep going downstream for cleaner, quieter and healthier campsites. 661.6 Helena Bridge (Hernando DeSoto Bridge -- US Hwy 49) Paddlers: aim for whichever bridge opening is not occupied by towboat traffic and stay away from the pylons. The parent's mantra "Look both ways before crossing" applies here! Downstream Tows might be descending from behind Buck Island still hidden from your view. Monitor channel 13 on your VHF Marine radio. If in doubt announce yourself and ask any pilot in the area for recommendations. In general the left-most opening LBD is the least-used, hence safest opening, but it's a long paddle from the Harbor opening. The fastest water flows through the right-hand opening RBD. This is also the most traffic-prone opening due to the many industrial docking facilities, fleeting, towboat and support boat activity found along the Arkansas shore RBD. Floating underneath a bridge is one of the most sensational of Mississippi River experiences. For the paddler on the wide open Mississippi River it's difficult to get a sense of motion, speed, and the river current. Sometimes it feels like you are sitting in a lake not a river, even though you are indeed floating within the throes of the biggest and most powerful river in North America! That is until you pass underneath a bridge. As you scoot downstream the water piles up high against the bridge pylons and then swirls around the backside with violent convulsions and contortions of water, and you will enjoy the distinct sensation of river motion as the bridge abutments mysteriously slide by and the geometric truss work and solid

concrete road bed swing overhead with surprising speed, the higher the water the faster the speed. At high water this experience can be slightly disconcerting so fast the bridge slides by with sickening sucking sounds and explosions of agitated water. If you entertained any previous doubt about the power of the big river it will now be forever dashed away!

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Note: the bridge pylon is a very dangerous place for any paddler, regardless of river level. Keep at least twenty-boat lengths away from it (~100 yards), and never try to enter the eddying waters below. Passing towboats will make any already agitated places like the waters surrounding a bridge pylon to react even more violently. Do not underestimate the power of water against piers or pylons! My first journey down the Mississippi River ended in disaster at the foot of some huge concrete pylons similar to those found below the Helena Bridge. After a 5 month journey from Minnesota's North Woods in 1982/83 my best friend and I wrecked our 12 x 24 foot raft on a pylon supporting a TVA Power line crossing below Memphis. The snarling water wrapped our "invincible" raft around the base of the tower and snapped it like a potato chip. It was February and we weren't in wetsuits. I shouldn't even be alive now to tell this story. This is the only bridge in between Memphis and Greenville, over 200 miles of river. And such is the nature of the Lower Mississippi, and what makes this water trail such an attractive adventure for wilderness paddlers. The wildness of the Lower Mississippi River is reflected by the fact that there are so few crossings. 657 LBD Yazoo Pass You will travel near the historic opening of Yazoo Pass as you paddle around Montezuma Bend starting near mile 657. The Yazoo Pass used to connect the Mississippi River via Moon Lake to the Tallahatchie River system, and was one of the many routes that Grant used trying to sneak behind the rebel stronghold of Vicksburg. 2300 men on steamboats churned their way through this pass in 1863, but were repulsed 123 miles downstream at Fort Pemberton by a small Confederate force shielded by a sunken steamboat fortified with cotton bales. How to get into the old entrance of the Yazoo Pass: As you paddle down into Montezuma Bend Mile 657-Mile 652 (Friars Point) and the water is above twenty on the Helena Gauge (20 HG) you can sneak in behind a series of islands LBD that have grown up along the Montezuma Dikes. There are a series of three long dikes starting with #1 opposite & a little below Fitzhugh Landing at 657.6, #2 at 657 and #3 at 656.5 all Left Bank Descending. To get into the Yazoo Pass you will need to dive into the young willow islands formed behind #1 or #2. By the time you get to #3 it will be

too late. Look for the buoys that indicate the ends of the dikes and pick the best-looking opening and charge in! (Note: buoys are sometimes knocked out of place by high water or renegade tows running too close to the edge of the channel) You really can't go wrong, but beware water rushing in through the trees (snags) and accumulations of driftwood piled against stands of willows (strainers). Pick your best opening and jump in for a backwoods view of this interesting series of young willow-choked islands. Oftentimes lesser & greater egrets roost on these willows alongside the great blue heron and other waders, in the fall & winter double breasted cormorants enjoy these wetlands and white pelicans sometimes make rest stops as they soaring through on their transcontinental migration.

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There is a channel entering hard left all the way against the old revetment Mississippi Bank LBD below the last long dike at Mile 656.5. The trained eye will see the opening by the subtle changes of trees lines, young willows closer, the older forest rising on top of the higher forest bottoms behind with a slightly different canopy of giant oaks, sweetgums, sycamores, cottonwoods, and others, the classic trees of the bottomland hardwood forest. In higher water levels you will have to hug the willow tree line LBD to find the opening so strong does the water flow through, and once you go over the dike line it'll be too late to paddle back up into the Pass. Warning: at medium waters this dike line (#3 at 656.5) will be an explosion of agitated water, fast swirling octopus arms of water motivated by blooming boils with following whirlpools, roughest between HG 20-25, it becomes smoothed over above HG 26. Once you round the peninsula of willows, you will enter a strikingly beautiful narrow channel running north parallel to the tall woods along the Mississippi shore. The water calms out (except at high water when there is a gentle current) and you can paddle several hundred yards at med water. The quiet & peacefulness of the setting is a welcome contrast to the boisterous main channel. If the water's high and you want to do some exploring through the deep woods, you can paddle several miles following the remnants of the old channel, above flood stage you can paddle right up to the levee which now cuts the Pass off from its former route to Moon Lake. Now imagine 2300 soldiers on fortified steamboats entering this same channel (which was about the same width at its mouth back then)! At med river level the waters of the Pass will be a delightful clearish-greenish hue, much clearer than the muddy waters of the main channel. If you are a strong swimmer and know how to self-rescue, it's a beautiful place to jump out of

your canoe and take a refreshing swim. [CLICK HERE: for Safe Swimming in the Mississippi]. At higher water levels, the muddy main channel submerges the islands and invades all the willow forests and spills into the Pass. LBD: Alternate Route to Vicksburg: Yazoo Pass For the long distance paddler weary of the monotony of the main channel, and ready for an adventure into the “heart of darkness,” a parallel journey down the legendary Yazoo-Mississippi Delta could be made -- to rejoin the river 338 miles downstream at Vicksburg. It’s not a shortcut; in fact it’s a long-cut, over one hundred miles longer. It’s an oftentimes moody, gloomy journey through blues drenched landscapes of the cotton-kingdom. It will involve at least one long portage through poison ivy, thorny, caney, snake-infested, mosquito-ravaged thickets. Once you reach the Coldwater River it’s good water all the way, although most likely much slower than the Mississippi. Why do it? For the history, for the culture, for a backdoor view into the heart of the Mississippi Delta, but primarily for -- the adventure! While several miles of the pass have been cut off by the levee and later Mississippi Highway 1, you can today paddle across Moon Lake (oxbow lake, old Mississippi River channel) and find the pass on its northern shoreline, behind Uncle Henry’s B&B and fine dining (old Moon Lake Casino). Your best and definitely easiest route however would be to arrange a shuttle from Helena to Moon Lake, and put in at the BMW store Boat Ramp.

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In wet seasons there will be water all the way through the 14 mile long Yazoo Pass from Moon Lake to the Coldwater River, but in times of drought short portages might be necessary at several shallows. As its name implies, Yazoo Pass is an active pass. When Moon Lake is getting the rainfall the water flows east towards the Coldwater. However when the Coldwater is rising the pass might be flowing west into Moon Lake. With some determination (also a machete and shrub saw are helpful) you can reach the Coldwater River, and follow the old trade routes down the Coldwater to the Tallahatchie, 117.5 miles down to the city of Greenwood where the Union soldiers were repulsed by a tiny rebel faction at Fort Pemberton (today nothing but a historic site where the Tallahatchie approaches Hwy 82). Along the way the Coldwater/Tallahatchie system receives waters from all Mississippi Hill Country tributaries like the Yocona. This is the same hill country that produced the Hill Country Blues tradition; indeed all of these waterways drain the former homes of legendary musicians like Mississippi Fred McDowell, Jessie Mae Hemphill, Junior Kimbrough and R.L. Burnside. Along the way the Tallahatchie

flows along past by important landmarks like the famed Tallahatchie River Bridge where Billy Joe McAllister met his sad fate (Bobby Gentry), the infamous Money Bridge where Emmett Till was murdered and ignited the Civil Rights era and lastly the Little Zion Church, one of Robert Johnson's 3 disputed gravesites (all are located on or near the Tallahatchie/Yazoo -- see below for more info). As the Tallahatchie rounds Greenwood, the most wild & beautiful of all Hill Country tributaries the Yalobusha River comes rolling in from the East, the two rivers join to form the Yazoo, the famed "River of Death." The Yazoo rebounds westward following an ancient channel of the Ohio River flowing along past Cotton Row/Downtown Greenwood (good public landing) and then downstream past Three Forks (where Robert Johnson was reportedly murdered), Mt. Zion (another location where he is reportedly buried!), and from thence through Panther Burn, Yazoo City, Satartia, Redwood, and finally Vicksburg. Just above Vicksburg the Yazoo the River of Death receives all the waters of the Mississippi Delta with the entrance of the Sunflower River through the Steele Bayou Control Structure. If a raindrop falls in the Mississippi Delta (and a lot of them fall -- in fact an annual average of 55 inches of rain) it doesn't enter the Mississippi directly, but follows it in many parallel side streams creeks & bayous like the Big Sunflower River, the Hushpuckena, the Quiver River, Deer Creek and Steele Bayou, all of which enter the Sunflower somewhere along its 250 mile long route and then are all delivered to the Yazoo at this junction, ten miles above Vicksburg and the confluence of the Yazoo with the mother Mississippi. The largest freshwater pumps in the world were going to be constructed at the Steele Bayou Control Structure, a project known as the Yazoo Pumps; it was killed in 2010 by the EPA. Yazoo Pass Mileage: Helena to Levee via Yazoo Pass: 9 miles Levee to Moon Lake NW shore: 2 miles Moon Lake NW shore to Yazoo Pass: 2 miles Alternate Start: BMW ramp to Yazoo Pass: 1 mile Yazoo Pass Moon Lake to Coldwater River: 14 miles Coldwater River to Tallahatchie River: 49 miles Tallahatchie River to Yalobusha River: 68.5 miles Yazoo River: Yalobusha to Vicksburg: 188 miles Total: Helena to Vicksburg via Yazoo Pass = 332.5 miles (Compare: Helena to Vicksburg on Mississippi River = 226 miles)

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Rivers & Robert Johnson: The Mississippi Delta where the Delta Blues was born and thrived is not the Delta of the Mississippi River. That's right, this delta is actually an independent floodplain formed by the big river and its smaller tributary the Yazoo. The "Delta Blues" that was born &

fostered under the phenomenal careers of genius musicians like Muddy Waters, Charlie Patton, Robert Johnson refers geographically to the Yazoo-Mississippi Delta, which is a mussel shell-shaped alluvial floodplain bounded by the Mississippi and the Yazoo-Tallahatchie-Coldwater River systems running approximately two hundred miles between Memphis and Vicksburg, and sixty miles at its widest between Greenville and Greenwood. Robert Johnson's life is tied into Yazoo River, the River of Death, by the many places that highlight his life and death. All of these places can be visited by canoe, kayak or SUP. However the landings are not marked and paddlers will have to use maps, GPS and their orientation skills to locate the best places to land and then walk to the below: Mileage from Downtown Greenwood Public Boat Launch: Little Zion Church: along the Tallahatchie River 15 river miles north of Greenwood Three Forks Store: Yazoo River, 25 miles south of Greenwood Payne Chapel: Yazoo River, 15 miles south of Greenwood (+ 2 mile hike) Mount Zion MB Church: Yazoo River, 35 miles south of Greenwood LBD 656 East Montezuma Bar A shaggy mile-long Island with a large back channel that can be run above 20HG. Notoriously turbulent waters are found boiling along its top end main channel, and all along its long dike which connects to the Mississippi shore, novice paddlers should avoid crossing this dike until the water is higher than 25HG. 657-654 RBD Montezuma Towhead A three-mile long island at low water, one mile-long at medium, no sand at 35HG, goes completely under at flood stage 44HG. Montezuma Towhead was created when an unfortunate steamboat by the same name The Montezuma happened upon a snag in this section of river and sank on Feb 28, 1829. Snags were not uncommon back then, steamboat pilots avoided them like the plague, as is well narrated in Mark Twain's 1883 Life on the Mississippi . Less well-known are the towheads, islands, bars and other important river features that have been wrought out of these wreckages as they lay on the bottom of the river and create conditions that lead to sediment accumulation on their downstream side out of the vast oceans of sediment that are always there in motion. The emergence of Montezuma Towhead forced the entire Mississippi River eastward one mile and the ill-fated town of Delta, Mississippi, was consumed by collapsing banks. Delta was neck-and-neck with Friars Point as the leading town of Coahoma County. Its promising future cut short by the sinking of a steamboat and the insatiable appetite of the river. Friars Point didn't enjoy its glory days long as victor in this race for prominence, its place on the river left high & dry by the opposite big river tendency: to create land. Keep reading below for the rest of the story.

**Mile 654.7 LBD — Montezuma Landing Possible shuttle access to Clarksdale via Highway 1 and the Friars Point Road (17.5 miles). Note: If you want to access Friars Point for resupply or visit continue downstream two miles to Friars Point Landing. The riverbank LBD along Montezuma Bend undulates in and out of several small harbors, the last and largest of these at mile 653 is Montezuma Landing. Also known as "Delta Landing" (for the town of Delta which was eaten by the river in the mid nineteenth century -- see above). At the north end of this open-mouthed harbor you will find a steep & narrow concrete ramp which is usable at low, medium and high waters up to 37HG when the parking lot and landing becomes submerged. As always, paddlers can enter and exit the river wherever the road ends (and the water begins) at higher water levels, if necessary right off the levee. Below 10HG the end of the concrete ramp steepens considerably and much caution is required when backing down. This ramp ends completely around 0HG, which can be troublesome to powerboats on trailers, but only means a short portage for any paddlers. Below the end of the ramp you will encounter piles of rip rap which fall off steeply into the dark depths of the eddy. Drivers: if you back down this ramp at any levels, be sure to set your emergency brake and chock your tires with rocks from the adjacent rip-rap! At medium and low water levels and small sand dune forms at the southern edge of the landing, piles of sand pushed up by the swirling waters of a giant eddy which is found here. Use the eddy to your advantage entering or exiting Montezuma Landing. Possible emergency campsite, with good protection from south or southeasterly winds, but also accessible to motorized vehicles and sometimes a popular picnic and party place. Shuttle Route Montezuma to Clarksdale: http://maps.google.com/maps/ms?msid=217859314001592865582.0004b836f81f9559f31a1&msa=0&ll=34.28729,-90.55687&spn=0.440242,0.804749 Short URL: http://g.co/maps/xfbcq 652 LBD Friars Point Friars Point was once the major population**

> **center and seat of Coahoma County. Friars Point was located right on the river, the downtown a levee landing where cotton was loaded onto steamboats, and gamblers might be seen strolling the streets looking for the next unwary victim. Clarksdale at the time was just a distant dream of a frontier woodcutter named John Clark. The unpredictable Mississippi ate the entire length of First Street one year. No problem, the resourceful citizens simply moved commerce back to Second Street and it became center of activity for its business district. Many a good story came from any puzzled visitor inspecting the signage and wondering why there wasn't any First Street and why Second Street was the center of activity.**

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But the big river got the last laugh when it decided to migrate westward and instead of commanding a good steamboat landing, Friars Point was left with nothing but sandbars and mud bars, its downtown approachable only in high water. The river might as well have banished Friars Point to the middle of the Gobi Desert so dislocated it now found itself. When the railroad tracks of the Illinois Central Railroad were laid through Clarksdale, Friars Point rescinded its prominence as County Seat, and then lost the newspaper and major banks. Still, the town is easily accessed at mile 652.5 by anyone paddling through the area using an unimproved & very primitive landing at the edge of town, directly below the Mississippi Limestone/ADM complex. There is an obvious open sandbar below all of the granaries and piles of gravel and docking facilities. The Yazoo-Mississippi Levee Board has made repeated attempts to improve the landing, but every high water the river re-takes command. Make your landing there for access to Friars Point, and also to get to Clarksdale. Paddlers, be sure to hide your vessel well, and remove any items of value. If you need to get to Clarksdale your best bet is to bring your canoe or kayak and all your gear with you. Remember, the unwritten rule of the river rat is if it's not locked it's fair game. You can camp here if necessary, but beware midnight visitors. Better option: visit town and then push off to camp further downstream. Even within the shadow of its blues-tourism drenched neighbor, Clarksdale, there are many reasons to walk over the levee for a quick visit. Friars Point was the Childhood home of Conway Twitty and Aretha Franklin's Daddy, The Rev. C.L. Franklin. The postal packet the Kate Adams made regular landings here en route Arkansas City and Memphis. Muddy Waters reported seeing

Robert Johnson perform in front of Hirsberg Grocery. The bench that Robert Johnson performed on still sits in front of the grocery, now painted fire-engine red. Friars Point was the original ferry landing for access to Helena. All blues musicians in the area passed through to get to Helena's influential King Biscuit Time radio program. If you stop, be sure to visit the North Delta Museum and Icehouse Antiques. Paddlers can find a limited selection of groceries at a couple of markets, one of which has noteworthy take-out lunches quick fried on a gigantic iron wok. Friars Point also has a liquor store and a post office. LBD 652.5 Friars Point Landing (unimproved) Several hundred yards below the McAlister Grain/Mississippi Limestone complex (you will see a line of shiny stainless steel grain elevators and piles of gravel and anchored tows) you can find a serviceable landing with access to Friars Point. Unimproved location. Primitive landing on muddy banks topped with sandy/muddy flats. Not recommended camping. Hide your vessel above or below and carry all valuables if you leave landing to visit Friars Point. At low water steep muddy banks with gooey muddy bottoms. At high water landing becomes submerged around HG 35, but paddlers can simply pull in wherever a good spot is found along the levee. What's to come further downstream: Below Friars Point the big river convulses like a lazy snake on a hot summer day into the enormous floodplain added onto with the waters and wetlands of the Arkansas and the White Rivers. The Arkansas is the largest tributary below the Ohio and its single highest drainage, having come from the Central Colorado Rockies. This is the biggest river in North America and it sure feels like it! Go on to the next section of the Rivergator for more mouth-watering descriptions of the Big River! CLICK HERE for the next Appendix

# Appendix

# Appendix

*Memphis to Helena — Mile 737-663*

Appendix Rivergator: Memphis to Helena MM 736 - 663 --- Addendum 1: Helena, Arkansas From Mark Twain’s Life on the Mississippi Helena occupies one of the prettiest situations on the Mississippi. Her perch is the last, the southernmost group of hills which one sees on that side of the river. In its normal condition it is a pretty town; but the flood (or possibly the seepage) had lately been ravaging it; whole streets of houses had been invaded by the muddy water, and the outsides of the buildings were still belted with a broad stain extending upwards from the foundations. Stranded and discarded scows lay all about; plank sidewalks on stilts four feet high were still standing; the board sidewalks on the ground level were loose and ruinous,—a couple of men trotting along them could make a blind man think a cavalry charge was coming; everywhere the mud was black and deep, and in many places malarious pools of stagnant water were standing. A Mississippi inundation is the next most wasting and desolating infliction to a fire. (Twain: Life on the Mississippi Chapter XXX) --- Addendum 2: The Wreck of the Pennsylvania and death of Mark Twain’s Brother Henry Clemmons near Ship Island (in what is now Tunica Lake). From Mark Twain’s Life on the Mississippi It was six o'clock on a hot summer morning. The 'Pennsylvania' was creeping along, north of Ship Island, about sixty miles below Memphis on a half-head of steam, towing a wood-flat which was fast being emptied. George Ealer was in the pilot-house-alone, I think; the second engineer and a striker had the watch in the engine room; the second mate had the watch on deck; George Black, Mr. Wood, and my brother, clerks, were asleep, as were also Brown and the head engineer, the carpenter, the chief mate, and one striker; Captain Klinefelter was in the barber's chair, and the barber was preparing to shave him. There were a good many cabin passengers aboard and three or four hundred deck passengers—so it was said at the time—and not very many of them were astir. The wood being nearly all out of the flat now, Ealer rang to 'come ahead' full steam, and the next moment four of the eight boilers exploded with a thunderous crash, and the whole forward third of the boat was hoisted toward the sky! The main part of the mass, with the chimneys, dropped upon the boat again, a mountain of riddled and chaotic rubbish—and then, after a little, fire broke out.

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Many people were flung to considerable distances, and fell in

the river; among these were Mr. Wood and my brother, and the carpenter. The carpenter was still stretched upon his mattress when he struck the water seventy-five feet from the boat. Brown, the pilot, and George Black, chief clerk, were never seen or heard of after the explosion. The barber's chair, with Captain Klinefelter in it and unhurt, was left with its back overhanging vacancy—everything forward of it, floor and all, had disappeared; and the stupefied barber, who was also unhurt, stood with one toe projecting over space, still stirring his lather unconsciously, and saying, not a word. When George Ealer saw the chimneys plunging aloft in front of him, he knew what the matter was; so he muffled his face in the lapels of his coat, and pressed both hands there tightly to keep this protection in its place so that no steam could get to his nose or mouth. He had ample time to attend to these details while he was going up and returning. He presently landed on top of the unexploded boilers, forty feet below the former pilot-house, accompanied by his wheel and a rain of other stuff, and enveloped in a cloud of scalding steam. All of the many who breathed that steam, died; none escaped. But Ealer breathed none of it. He made his way to the free air as quickly as he could; and when the steam cleared away he returned and climbed up on the boilers again, and patiently hunted out each and every one of his chessmen and the several joints of his flute. By this time the fire was beginning to threaten. Shrieks and groans filled the air. A great many persons had been scalded, a great many crippled; the explosion had driven an iron crowbar through one man's body—I think they said he was a priest. He did not die at once, and his sufferings were very dreadful. A young French naval cadet, of fifteen, son of a French admiral, was fearfully scalded, but bore his tortures manfully. Both mates were badly scalded, but they stood to their posts, nevertheless. They drew the wood-boat aft, and they and the captain fought back the frantic herd of frightened immigrants till the wounded could be brought there and placed in safety first. When Mr. Wood and Henry fell in the water, they struck out for shore, which was only a few hundred yards away; but Henry presently said he believed he was not hurt (what an unaccountable error!), and therefore would swim back to the boat and help save the wounded. So they parted, and Henry returned. By this time the fire was making fierce headway, and several persons who were imprisoned under the ruins were begging piteously for help. All efforts to conquer the fire proved fruitless; so the buckets were presently thrown aside and the officers fell-to with axes and tried to cut the prisoners out. A striker was one of the captives; he said he was not injured, but could not free himself; and when he saw that the fire was likely to drive away

the workers, he begged that someone would shoot him, and thus save him from the more dreadful death. The fire did drive the axmen away, and they had to listen, helpless, to this poor fellow's supplications till the flames ended his miseries.

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The fire drove all into the wood-flat that could be accommodated there; it was cut adrift, then, and it and the burning steamer floated down the river toward Ship Island. They moored the flat at the head of the island, and there, unsheltered from the blazing sun, the half-naked occupants had to remain, without food or stimulants, or help for their hurts, during the rest of the day. A steamer came along, finally, and carried the unfortunates to Memphis, and there the most lavish assistance was at once forthcoming. By this time Henry was insensible. The physicians examined his injuries and saw that they were fatal, and naturally turned their main attention to patients who could be saved. Forty of the wounded were placed upon pallets on the floor of a great public hall, and among these was Henry. There the ladies of Memphis came every day, with flowers, fruits, and dainties and delicacies of all kinds, and there they remained and nursed the wounded. All the physicians stood watches there, and all the medical students; and the rest of the town furnished money, or whatever else was wanted. And Memphis knew how to do all these things well; for many a disaster like the 'Pennsylvania's' had happened near her doors, and she was experienced, above all other cities on the river, in the gracious office of the Good Samaritan.' The sight I saw when I entered that large hall was new and strange to me. Two long rows of prostrate forms—more than forty, in all—and every face and head a shapeless wad of loose raw cotton. It was a gruesome spectacle. I watched there six days and nights, and a very melancholy experience it was. There was one daily incident which was peculiarly depressing: this was the removal of the doomed to a chamber apart. It was done in order that the morale of the other patients might not be injuriously affected by seeing one of their numbers in the death-agony. The fated one was always carried out with as little stir as possible, and the stretcher was always hidden from sight by a wall of assistants; but no matter: everybody knew what that cluster of bent forms, with its muffled step and its slow movement meant; and all eyes watched it wistfully, and a shudder went abreast of it like a wave. I saw many poor fellows removed to the 'death-room,' and saw them no more afterward. But I saw our chief mate carried thither more than once. His hurts were frightful, especially his scalds. He was clothed in linseed oil and raw cotton to his waist, and

resembled nothing human. He was often out of his mind; and then his pains would make him rave and shout and sometimes shriek. Then, after a period of dumb exhaustion, his disordered imagination would suddenly transform the great apartment into a forecastle, and the hurrying throng of nurses into the crew; and he would come to a sitting posture and shout, 'Hump yourselves, hump yourselves, you petrifactions, snail-bellies, pall-bearers going to be all day getting that hatful of freight out?' and supplement this explosion with a firmament-obliterating irruption or profanity which nothing could stay or stop till his crater was empty. And now and then while these frenzies possessed him, he would tear off handfuls of the cotton and expose his cooked flesh to view. It was horrible. It was bad for the others, of course—this noise and these exhibitions; so the doctors tried to give him morphine to quiet him. But, in his mind or out of it, he would not take it. He said his wife had been killed by that treacherous drug,

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and he would die before he would take it. He suspected that the doctors were concealing it in his ordinary medicines and in his water—so he ceased from putting either to his lips. Once, when he had been without water during two sweltering days, he took the dipper in his hand, and the sight of the limpid fluid, and the misery of his thirst, tempted him almost beyond his strength; but he mastered himself and threw it away, and after that he allowed no more to be brought near him. Three times I saw him carried to the death-room, insensible and supposed to be dying; but each time he revived, cursed his attendants, and demanded to be taken back. He lived to be mate of a steamboat again. But he was the only one who went to the death-room and returned alive. Dr. Peyton, a principal physician, and rich in all the attributes that go to constitute high and flawless character, did all that educated judgment and trained skill could do for Henry; but, as the newspapers had said in the beginning, his hurts were past help. On the evening of the sixth day his wandering mind busied itself with matters far away, and his nerveless fingers 'picked at his coverlet.' His hour had struck; we bore him to the death-room, poor boy. (Twain: Life on the Mississippi Chapter XX) --- Addendum 3: Cutoffs From Mark Twain’s Life on the Mississippi THESE dry details are of importance in one particular. They give me an opportunity of introducing one of the Mississippi's oddest peculiarities,—that of shortening its length from time to time. If you will throw a long, pliant apple-paring over your shoulder, it will pretty fairly shape itself into an average section of the Mississippi River; that is, the nine or ten hundred miles stretching from Cairo, Illinois, southward to

New Orleans, the same being wonderfully crooked, with a brief straight bit here and there at wide intervals. The two hundred-mile stretch from Cairo northward to St. Louis is by no means so crooked, that being a rocky country which the river cannot cut much. The water cuts the alluvial banks of the 'lower' river into deep horseshoe curves; so deep, indeed, that in some places if you were to get ashore at one extremity of the horseshoe and walk across the neck, half or three quarters of a mile, you could sit down and rest a couple of hours while your steamer was coming around the long elbow, at a speed of ten miles an hour, to take you aboard again. When the river is rising fast, some scoundrel whose plantation is back in the country, and therefore of inferior value, has only to watch his chance, cut a little gutter across the narrow neck of land some dark night, and turn the water into it, and in a wonderfully short time a miracle has happened: to wit, the whole Mississippi has taken possession of that little ditch, and placed the countryman's plantation on its bank (quadrupling its value), and that other party's formerly valuable plantation finds itself away out yonder on a big island; the old watercourse around it will soon shoal up, boats cannot approach within ten miles of it, and down goes its value to a fourth of its former worth. Watches are kept on those narrow necks, at needful times, and if a man happens to be caught cutting a ditch across them, the chances are all against his ever having another opportunity to cut a ditch.

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Pray observe some of the effects of this ditching business. Once there was a neck opposite Port Hudson, Louisiana, which was only half a mile across, in its narrowest place. You could walk across there in fifteen minutes; but if you made the journey around the cape on a raft, you traveled thirty-five miles to accomplish the same thing. In 1722 the river darted through that neck, deserted its old bed, and thus shortened itself thirty-five miles. In the same way it shortened itself twenty-five miles at Black Hawk Point in 1699. Below Red River Landing, Raccourci cut-off was made (forty or fifty years ago, I think). This shortened the river twenty-eight miles. In our day, if you travel by river from the southernmost of these three cut-offs to the northernmost, you go only seventy miles. To do the same thing a hundred and seventy-six years ago, one had to go a hundred and fifty-eight miles!—shortening of eighty-eight miles in that trifling distance. At some forgotten time in the past, cut-offs were made above Vidalia, Louisiana; at island 92; at island 84; and at Hale's Point. These shortened the river, in the aggregate, seventy-seven miles. Since my own day on the Mississippi, cut-offs have been made at Hurricane

Island; at island 100; at Napoleon, Arkansas; at Walnut Bend; and at Council Bend. These shortened the river, in the aggregate, sixty-seven miles. In my own time a cut-off was made at American Bend, which shortened the river ten miles or more. Therefore, the Mississippi between Cairo and New Orleans was twelve hundred and fifteen miles long one hundred and seventy-six years ago. It was eleven hundred and eighty after the cut-off of 1722. It was one thousand and forty after the American Bend cut-off. It has lost sixty-seven miles since. Consequently its length is only nine hundred and seventy-three miles at present. Now, if I wanted to be one of those ponderous scientific people, and 'let on' to prove what had occurred in the remote past by what had occurred in a given time in the recent past, or what will occur in the far future by what has occurred in late years, what an opportunity is here! Geology never had such a chance, nor such exact data to argue from! Nor 'development of species,' either! Glacial epochs are great things, but they are vague—vague. Please observe:— In the space of one hundred and seventy-six years the Lower Mississippi has shortened itself two hundred and forty-two miles. That is an average of a trifle over one mile and a third per year. Therefore, any calm person, who is not blind or idiotic, can see that in the Old Oolitic Silurian Period,' just a million years ago next November, the Lower Mississippi River was upwards of one million three hundred thousand miles long, and stuck out over the Gulf of Mexico like a fishing-rod. And by the same token any person can see that seven hundred and forty-two years from now the Lower Mississippi will be only a mile and three-quarters long, and Cairo and New Orleans will have joined their streets together, and be plodding comfortably along under a single mayor and a mutual board of aldermen. There is something fascinating about science. One gets such wholesale returns of conjecture out of such a trifling investment of fact.

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When the water begins to flow through one of those ditches I have been speaking of, it is time for the people thereabouts to move. The water cleaves the banks away like a knife. By the time the ditch has become twelve or fifteen feet wide, the calamity is as good as accomplished, for no power on earth can stop it now. When the width has reached a hundred yards, the banks begin to peel off in slices half an acre wide. The current flowing around the bend traveled formerly only five miles an hour; now it is tremendously increased by the shortening of the distance. I was on board the first boat that tried to go through the cut-off at American Bend, but we did not get through. It was toward midnight, and a wild night it

was—thunder, lightning, and torrents of rain. It was estimated that the current in the cut-off was making about fifteen or twenty miles an hour; twelve or thirteen was the best our boat could do, even in tolerably slack water, therefore perhaps we were foolish to try the cut-off. However, Mr. Brown was ambitious, and he kept on trying. The eddy running up the bank, under the 'point,' was about as swift as the current out in the middle; so we would go flying up the shore like a lightning express train, get on a big head of steam, and 'stand by for a surge' when we struck the current that was whirling by the point. But all our preparations were useless. The instant the current hit us it spun us around like a top, the water deluged the forecastle, and the boat careened so far over that one could hardly keep his feet. The next instant we were away down the river, clawing with might and main to keep out of the woods. We tried the experiment four times. I stood on the forecastle companion way to see. It was astonishing to observe how suddenly the boat would spin around and turn tail the moment she emerged from the eddy and the current struck her nose. The sounding concussion and the quivering would have been about the same if she had come full speed against a sand-bank. Under the lightning flashes one could see the plantation cabins and the goodly acres tumble into the river; and the crash they made was not a bad effort at thunder. Once, when we spun around, we only missed a house about twenty feet, that had a light burning in the window; and in the same instant that house went overboard. Nobody could stay on our forecastle; the water swept across it in a torrent every time we plunged athwart the current. At the end of our fourth effort we brought up in the woods two miles below the cut-off; all the country there was overflowed, of course. A day or two later the cut-off was three-quarters of a mile wide, and boats passed up through it without much difficulty, and so saved ten miles. (Twain: Life on the Mississippi Chapter XVII) --- Addendum 4: Low Water on the Lower Mississippi From John Ruskey Lower Mississippi River Dispatch Vol. 8 No 9, September 2012

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How Low Can You Go? Yes, the river has gotten too low for many of the steel monsters that ply its waters. It has gotten too low for 7x7 barge tows fully loaded. It’s too low for the largest steamboat ever, the American Queen, to leave its new home in the Beale Street Harbor of Memphis. The channel is shallow and the shoals of course shallower. Some harbors like Lake Providence Louisiana got silted in last year’s flood and now need dredging to remain open. But no, it’s not too low for fish or paddlers. Certainly not too low for waders and water

birds like the least tern, who were recently counted (July 2012, Dr. Ken Jones) and numbered close to 10,000 individuals in 75 colonies. Wow, nice recovery from last year's flood! Beavers have had to move summer quarters to their low water burrows and have been working hard to keep channels open. Us paddlers, we're similar to the beavers. We think there is plenty of water. It just requires a longer route to get there! Most ramps end in mud or rip-rap. For us paddlers that just means we have to carry our vessels a little further to reach the water's edge. And no, contrary to popular reports it hasn't lost any of its power or majesty. We don't register power in cfs (cubic feet per second). Power is the ability of a scene to bring a person to awe, or humility. And the river hasn't lost any of that kind of power. And somberly enough it hasn't lost its power to drown the unprepared and unaware. If anything it has become more majestic and more awesome -- if nothing else than for the visual effect of the mind-boggling unending landscape of the still very wide and deep big river running in between steep muddy banks and giant piles of rip-rap, and convoluted sections of revetment that have been rolled up as surely as they were originally unrolled. Now exposed wrecks of barges and steamboats glare darkly and menacingly, along with deep muddy cuts into backwater places and slot channels which disappear into overhanging forests. The RV that rolled off the Natchez-Under--the-Hill ramp and twirled off underneath the Natchez Bridge last year has reappeared about a mile downstream. Some headline stories prosaically adopted the headline the "Mighty Mississippi River has lost its Might…" Hee-ee, very poetic, but that all depends on your perspective. From water level, or even from the banks of the river the view upstream and downstream is majestic, serene, the long views of water, while of course shorter than during high water, still occupy the majority of your view, but now instead of running side to side, forest to forest, from Tennessee to Arkansas, and from Arkansas to Mississippi and from Mississippi to Louisiana, now it is framed by long sweeping curves of dusty yellow sandbars reaching outwards from all the islands and many bankside places and slicing the river reach with simmering sandy sword slashes.

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On the other hand 100 miles of the Platte River ran dry (in Nebraska), and that's worrisome, especially this early in the season. I was born and raised along the headwaters of the Platte in the Colorado Front Range. It's the major river of the central plains, draining everything from the Front Range to the Snowy Range to the Rattlesnake Range, from Denver to

Laramie to Casper and eastward to its confluence with the Big Muddy Missouri below Omaha. The Platte River is not supposed to run dry. It receives waters from some of the major ranges of the Rocky Mountains and also the famously rich Oglala Aquifer of Nebraska. “I wonder what the bottom of the river looks like?” This is one of the most often repeated curiosities our clients press upon us as we’re floating along and buoyed by the bosom of the biggest river this side of the globe, the beautiful and mysterious Lower Mississippi River. After the summer of 2012, we’ll be able to answer succinctly and with personal knowledge. We are learning exactly what the bottom of the river looks like. And we don’t even need diving gear. Over one century ago James B. Eads walked the bottom of the river in a special diving bell he invented and learned it better than anyone before or since. But this year U.S. river runners don’t need any life-support system. We simply make a canoe or kayak or SUP landing and start walking! It’s a history lesson. It's biology (mostly dead stuff). It's geology. It's a class in river bottom geomorphology. Our walk takes us up and down endless dunes and layers of mud and sand and gravel, and small plankton pools full of flopping fish or their carcasses, and turtle tracks, and the remains of feasts of bald eagles and coyotes littering the shore line, and through the evidence of ancient forests, and alongside strange eruptions of blue and green mud, and blue logs now exposed and disintegrating in the presence of oxygen UV rays, and fields of driftwood and trash, and in between beams, posts and rotting piers and amongst barge wrecks and steamboat wrecks and through jumbled slabs of wood, things long covered by water are now unveiled, the bottoms of landings, the tops of lost dredges, and even the RV that disappeared last year at Natchez-Under-the-Hill! Everywhere we stop and walk and explore and play will eventually be covered up again in sliding layers of muddy water. The river is low now, but it will of course rise again as it always does. If you stay on the paved highway you won’t see it. If you stay on the gravel road you’ll miss it. If you stay on any road it can’t be accessed. If you stay on the “Great River Road,” you will see only gasping forests and glimpses of sand. But if you get on the “Real River Road,” you will see the rest of the story. Your road reaches only the high places. But our road goes wherever the water goes. And this year the real river road is low, low, low! As paddlers we of course have to stop wherever the water allows us to stop. And so we have been ending up on the edges of the long slivers of sand reaching out way out above and below the islands, the low water sequestering blue holes, mud holes, and making inlets along a ragged jigsaw shoreline longer and more tattered then the Maine shoreline (if you added up all of the

zigzag shoreline on all of the islands and channel in between St. Louis and the Gulf of Mexico).

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As you get into the belly of the island the long walls of rock called wing dams (that we are normally paddling over) now look like the Great Wall of China, and downstream below the walls they have created expansive bays of water then mud and finally sand behind. The water-loving willow trees have suffered and appear off-color and withered, especially the lines of willows on the higher ridges of sand. In previous years I have seen whole willow forests die to never recover from this kind of drought in low water. Everywhere dead fish are seen or smelled, in the mud, in the sand, in the water, piles of fish bones now bleached by the sun litter the beach, and on the water, it sometimes feels like a macabre parade of dead fish as you paddle along, so thick is the main channel full of fish bodies. Every time you paddle past one you can look ahead and see the next dead body bobbing in the rippling waves, gleaming white in the sunlight reflecting off their wet skin, rotting carcasses being attacked by other fish, turtles and turkey vultures. When they wash ashore they become coyote fodder. One year ago we were recovering from the highest water of the century. Now this year we're seeing the lowest waters since 1998, and it might be dropping lower, the low water season is just begun. Of course, for the towboats there's only one season, and that's grain season. Everyone from the farmers to towboat pilots are very nervous about the fate of this year's crop. But farmers and river pilots have always gambled with the weather, right? 9Why the radical changes from extreme highs to extreme lows? This is another one of the river's mysteries. But it has at least one historical precedent: the 1936 heat wave & drought were followed by the 1937 flood. Only 2012 has been hotter & drier than 1936. And only the Great Flood of 2011 came higher and bigger than 1937. Finally, on a sobering note, the Mississippi River is certainly not too low to drown in. Far too many people have been swallowed up this year. If anything, the extreme low water demands greater vigilance and precaution. Weird things always happen on this mysterious waterway, and even more weird things happen during any extreme conditions. The river seems to garner the fascination of the nation, in the press corps if nowhere else. A man drowned last week near the river hamlet of Louisiana, Missouri. The story hit Google news from -- not from St. Louis, nor Chicago, nor Des Moines, indeed not any regional paper, in fact not any paper within the entire Mississippi River drainage -- the story hit Google news from the Sacramento Bee. We see lots of Mississippi River stories

coming from that great newspaper of the capital city of the great bear state. Someone at the Sacramento Bee has interest in the river. Maybe because of their own river floodplain and the similarities. The river brings us all together, even in times of loss and heartache. Our condolences go out to the family of the bereaved. CLICK HERE for the next section


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